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PRACTICAL

LAB II : ADVANCED ASANAS AND PRANAYAMAS

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PRACTICAL
LAB II : ADVANCED ASANAS AND PRANAYAMAS

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INTRODUCTION

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One of the most commonly recognized and easily popular forms of exercise that one can find around themselves in this day and age is Yoga. This unique practice is meant to harmonize the physical, spiritual and mental practices of the humans. Yoga as a practice has been a part of Indian culture for centuries. In fact, it is a crucial part of the six ancient hindu philosophies. What distinguishes yoga from other forms of exercises is that fact that it integrates the achivement of spiritual wellbeing alongside the physical wellbeing. The practice of yoga is based on the foundation of certain principles like breathing, proper exercise, diet, meditation and reliazation.

Yoga is essentially a spiritual discipline based on an extremely subtle science which focuses on bringing harmony between mind and body. It is an art and science for healthy living. The word 'Yoga' is derived from the Sanskrit root yuj meaning 'to join', 'to yoke' or 'to unite'. According to Yogic scriptures, the practice of Yoga leads to the union of individual consciousness with universal consciousness.

Yoga asanas are of varied types. A categorization can be made on the purpose of their practice and on this basis they can be of meditative or cultural type. Another categorization is the position of the body while practicing such postures. On this basis, the asanas can be divided into sitting, standing, supine and prone postures. Pranayamas relate to the control of breath which can also be differentiated into the ratio of inhaling and exhaling.

This practical lab book, *Advanced Asanas and Pranayamas*, describes the methods and techniques of practicing various Asanas and Pranayamas.

MEDITATIVE POSTURES: SITTING POSTURES

NOTES

1. Siddhasana

English Name: The Accomplished Pose

Meaning: – Accomplish, achieve

Position: – Sitting

Siddhasana is a Sanskrit word in which the meaning of 'Siddha' is achieve, accomplish or finish and the meaning of 'asana' is sit, pose or posture. Siddhasana is another simple meditative pose use for meditation or other yogic activities. In term of Hath Yoga Pradipika (Yoga text) Siddhasana is the fourth very effective sitting poses which suited for Dhyan (meditation). In *Hatha Yoga Pradipika*, 84 different asanas are mentioned; in this text it is said that every yoga learner must attempt Siddhasana, among the eighty-four asanas. According to the meditation practitioners, Siddhasana is the second best sitting asana after Padmasana (Lotus Pose). Some yoga practitioners assume Siddhasana is the most effective of all asanas for meditation. According to Hatha Yoga Pradipika, the practice of this pose purifies all the 72,000 nadis or energy channels or energy gateways within the body, through which the prana flows. This asana is simple to perform and is suitable for everybody.

Steps of Siddhasana (The Accomplished Pose)

- First sit comfortably on the floor, keep your legs close to each other.
- Now keep your left foot at the perineum. (The area is that the soft tissue between the anus and also the male reproductive gland. Females ought to place their left foot within the labia majora of the vagina.)
- Now keep your right foot over your left foot.
- To create the pose steady, slide your right foot toes into the gap between the left calf muscles.
- Your knees ought to touch the ground.

NOTES

- Keep your spine erect during the process.
- You can press your chin against the chest.
- Keep focusing in the space between the eyebrows.
- You have to be attentive towards your respiration process.
- Breathing should be natural and deep.
- Place your hands on the knees, or you can make Jnana gesture or Chin gesture with the fingers.
- Remain in this position for as long as you can.

Benefits of Siddhasana (The Accomplished Pose)

- It is one of the important asana used for meditation. One can maintain this position for a long duration.
- It makes spinal column straight and steady.
- In Siddhasana, the heel is kept pressed against the Muladhara. This ensures that the energy currents flow upwards towards the spine.
- This asana gives the control over sex urge and the sexual functions.
- It stabilizes the nervous system.

2.Gomukhasana

English name: Cow Face Pose

Position: Sitting

The asana or posture of Gomukhasana has gained immense popularity within the yoga community. The asana, whose name literally translates into Cow Face Pose, has helped a lot of people who are fighting a variety of conditions such as diabetes, back and shoulder issues, and sexual disorders.

How to Go About It

- o Take a seat on the ground and keep your legs extended towards your front.
- o The left leg must be folded and placed under your right buttock.

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- The right leg should be folded and placed on top of your left thigh.
- After folding both legs, make sure to check that the knees of both the legs are placed near each other.
- Your left arm should be bent below the body and placed behind your back.
- Your right arm should be bent above your head and taken over your right shoulder, and placed at the back too. The two hands should manage to touch each other.
- Your body must be kept erect, and your chest should be expanding once you enter the final position.
- Concentrate on the breath after you settle into the final position.

The Benefits of Gomukhasana

- Works for people who have flexibility issues with their backs.
- Helps in easing stiff shoulders as well as various backaches and pains.
- Has immense benefits for diabetes patients.
- Stimulates renal activity.
- If practiced regularly, the chest muscles become well developed.
- Alleviates numerous sexual ailments.

Safety Measures

- While attempting to bring the hands together is an important part of this asana, try not to overdo it on your very first go. In the initial sessions, you may find that only the fingers of each hand manage to touch each other.
- People with existing medical conditions, especially back problems, should consult an expert first before practicing the Gomukhasana.

3. Padmasana

NOTES

English Name: Lotus pose

Position: Sitting

Steps and Benefits

Padma = Lotus,

asana = posture or pose or position

Pronounced : Pa-dah-maa-sun-aa

Padmasana or Lotus position is a cross-legged yoga posture which helps to deepen the meditation by calming the mind and alleviating various physical ailments. A regular practice of this posture aids in overall blossoming of the practitioner, just like a lotus; and hence the name Padmasana. In Chinese and Tibetan Buddhism, the Lotus pose is also known as **Vajra position.**

How to do Padmasana (Lotus Position)

1. Sit on the floor or on a mat with legs stretched out in front of you while keeping the spine erect.
2. Bend the right knee and place it on the left thigh. Make sure that the sole of the feet point upward and the heel is close to the abdomen.
3. Now, repeat the same step with the other leg.
4. With both the legs crossed and feet placed on opposite thighs, place your hands on the knees in mudra position.
5. Keep the head straight and spine erect.
6. Hold and continue with gentle long breaths in and out.

Mudras for Padmasana (Lotus Position)

Mudras stimulate the flow of energy in body and can have amazing effects when practiced with Padmasana. Every mudra differs from each other and so do their benefits. When sitting in Padmasana, you can deepen your meditation by incorporating either Chin mudra, Chinmayi mudra, Adi mudra or Bhrama mudra. Breathe for a few minutes while in the mudra and observe the flow of energy in the body.

Padmasana (Lotus Position) for Beginners

If you have problem overlapping both your legs and sitting in Padmasana, you may also sit in **Ardha – Padmasana** (Half – Lotus pose) by placing any one leg on the opposite thigh. Continue doing so till you feel flexible enough to progress to Padmasana.

NOTES

Benefits of the Padmasana (Lotus Position)

1. *Improves digestion*
2. Reduces muscular tension and brings blood pressure under control
3. Relaxes the mind
4. Helps pregnant ladies during childbirth
5. Reduces menstrual discomfort

Contraindications of the Padmasana (Lotus Position)

- Ankle or knee injury: Perform this pose only with the supervision of an experienced teacher.

Preparatory Poses before Padmasana (Lotus Position)

Padmasana can be followed by doing the following poses: Ardha Matsyendrasana, Badhakonasana, Janu Shirasasana.

4. Baddha Padmasana

English Name: Locked Lotus Pose

Position: Sitting

In Sanskrit the word 'Baddha' means bound or locked. Baddha Padmasana is also known as locked lotus pose, cause the parts of the body, during in Baddha Padmasana, are firmly locked up and solidified to reinforce its steadiness. During this posture, the toes are grasped by the fingers, along with the arms crossed from behind. This pose is the advance level of Padmasana. At first you have to master Padmasana and other basic asanas, and only after that you may practice this asana. If you are not able to perform this asana, in your first attempt, then do as much as you can, don't force yourself for performing this pose.

Steps of Baddha Padmasana (Locked Lotus Pose)

- Sit in the Padmasana (Lotus Pose); keep your feet high on your thighs, just close to the groin.
- Place your right arm behind to your back and reach round till your right hand is close to the left hip.
- Now bow forward a little; twist your trunk to your right side and try to grasp the right thumb of toe, resting on the left thigh firmly with the index finger and the middle finger.
- Sit straight and remain in the position for a few seconds.

NOTES

- Equivalently, place your left arm behind your back; crossing your right arm and try to reach round till your left hand is close to your right hip.
- Now bend forward a little. Twist your torso to the left and bring your shoulder blades together, try to grasp the left thumb of toe, resting on the right thigh firmly with the forefinger and the middle finger.
- Sit straight and remain in the position for a few seconds.
- Now your arms and legs are tightly locked.
- Try to keep your head, neck and spine straight.
- Your knees should press the ground.
- Look straight forward while breathing normally. (It is the final position of Baddha Padmasana.)
- Try to hold this pose for about ten seconds or as long as you can.
- Now release your hands and open the foot lock and come back to the initial position.
- Repeat the same process with your alternate legs and hands.

Benefits of Baddha Padmasana (Locked Lotus Pose)

- Makes your legs flexible.
- It stretches the joints of shoulders, wrists, back, elbows, hips, knees, ankles and makes them more flexible.
- Beneficial in shoulder and back pain.
- It improves the posture of the spine.
- It increases the range of the shoulder movements.
- It is beneficial in constipation and improves the functions of digestive system.

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- Daily practice of this asana is beneficial in Arthritis.
- Helps to make your spine straight.

Note:

Try to grasp the right thumb of your toe with the fingers of your right hand and the left thumb toe with the fingers of your left hand. This asana need needs a high degree of skill so attempt this pose only after mastering the basic asanas. Avoid this asana in case of knee injury, or severe back or shoulder pain. Pregnant women must avoid this pose. If you really want to get all the benefits of asana and pranayama you have to practice it daily. Supervision of well-educated trainer is strictly recommended.

CULTURAL POSTURES: PRONE

Prone pose is a restorative posture lying on the stomach that is typically used for resting, to calm the mind and to settle the breath.

1.Bhujangasana

Sanskrit: भुजाङ्गासन;

English Name: Cobra Pose (Bhujanga – Cobra, Asana – Pose)

Pronounced As – boo-jang-GAHS-anna

The eighth pose of the 12 poses of the Surya Namaskar, Bhujangasana is also called the Cobra Pose. This energizing backbend resembles the raised hood of a cobra.

What You Should Know Before You Do This Asana

You must make sure to keep your stomach and bowels empty before you practice this asana. Have your meals at least four to six hours before you do the asana so that your food gets digested and there is enough energy for you to expand during the practice.

It is best to practice yoga first thing in the morning. But in the event you cannot work out in the morning, it is alright to practice it in the evening.

Level: Basic

Style: Ashtanga Yoga

Duration: 15 to 30 seconds

Repetition: None

Stretches: Abdomen, Shoulders, Thorax, Lungs

Strengthens: Vertebral columns

NOTES

How to do Bhujangasana

1. Lie flat on your stomach. Place your hands on the side and ensure that your toes touch each other.
2. Then, move your hands to the front, making sure they are at the shoulder level, and place your palms on the floor.
3. Now, placing your body's weight on your palms, inhale and raise your head and trunk. Note that your arms should be bent at your elbows at this stage.
4. You need to arch your neck backward in an attempt to replicate the cobra with the raised hood. But make sure your shoulder blades are firm, and your shoulders are away from your ears.
5. Press your hips, thighs, and feet to the floor.
6. Hold the asana for about 15 to 30 seconds while breathing normally. Feel your stomach pressed against the floor. With practice, you should be able to hold the asana for up to two minutes.
7. To release the pose, slowly bring your hands back to the sides. Rest your head on the ground by bringing your forehead in contact with the floor. Place your hands under your head. Then, slowly rest your head on one side and breathe.

Precautions and Contraindications

This exercise should be avoided if you suffer from the following problems:

1. Hernia
2. Back injuries
3. Carpal tunnel syndrome
4. Headaches
5. Pregnancy
6. Recent abdominal surgeries

NOTES

Beginner's Tip

As a beginner, you must not go all into the asana. If you do so, you will end up straining your back and neck. You must find a height that suits you, and ensure you don't strain your back and neck. Once you do, take your hands off the floor for a moment so that you have a thorough extension.

The Benefits of the Cobra Pose

The following are some amazing benefits of Bhujangasana:

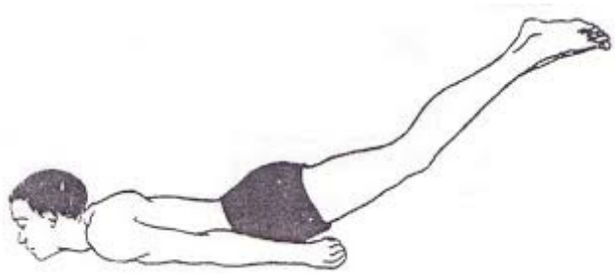
1. It is a deep backbend that makes the spine stronger and more flexible.
2. It tones the organs that lie in the lower abdomen.
3. It stimulates the digestive, reproductive, and urinary systems.
4. It helps regulate metabolism, thus balancing the weight.
5. It makes the buttocks firm.
6. It gives the lungs, shoulders, chest, and abdomen a good stretch.
7. It works as a great stress release.
8. It is known to open up the lungs and the heart.
9. It relieves sciatica and asthma.

The Science Behind the Bhujangasana

The Cobra Pose is one of those versatile yoga poses that is imperative in your yoga practice because it has some momentous health benefits. As mentioned earlier, it is a great backbend that also strengthens, tones, and flexes the spine. It makes the digestive and reproductive systems more efficient.

What's more, it works on opening up the chakras as well. Incidentally, the Bhujangasana works on four out of the seven chakras – the Visuddhi Chakra, the Anahata Chakra, the Manipura Chakra, and the Svadhisthana Chakra. Since this asana is practiced with the eyes open, as you look up, your optical nerves and vision benefit from it.

2. Salabhasana



Sanskrit: शलभासन;

English name: Locust/Grasshopper pose

Pronounced As – sha-la-BAHS-anna

This asana is one among the baby backbends. This pose seems simple, but is challenging. This is an asana you must include in your workout regimen.

What You Should Know Before You Do the Salabhasana

You must make sure to keep your stomach and bowels empty before you practice this asana. Have your meals at least four to six hours before you do the asana so that your food gets digested and there is enough energy for you to expend during the practice.

It is best to practice yoga first thing in the morning. But in the event you cannot work out in the morning, it is alright to practice it in the evening.

Level: Basic

Style: Vinyasa

Duration: 30 to 60 seconds

Repetition: None

Stretches: Shoulders, Thighs, Thorax, Navel

Strengthens: Legs, Vertebral columns, Arms, Buttocks

How to do the Salabhasana

1. Lie on your abdomen on the ground and place your hands by your side.
2. As you inhale, lift your legs and upper torso.
3. Using your inner thighs, lift your leg upwards without bending your knees. Your weight should rest on your lower ribs and abdomen.
4. Hold the pose for a minute. Release.

Precautions and Contraindications

1. If you are experiencing a headache or a migraine, or suffering from a neck or spinal injury, avoid this exercise.
2. Pregnant women also must avoid this asana at all costs.
3. In case you have a neck injury, you must ensure you look down at the floor and keep your head in a neutral position. You could also support your head on a folded blanket.

Beginner's Tip

Beginners can start by just lifting their legs, keeping their upper body on the ground. You may also use your hands for additional support.

NOTES

Advanced Pose Variation

To increase your stretch while you are in this asana, you must gently bend your knees, instead of stretching out your legs, such that your calf muscles are perpendicular to the ground. Once your legs are in position, lift your upper body – the torso, the arms, and the head – and lift your knees as high as you comfortably can. Then, as you lift the upper torso, head, and arms, lift the knees as far away from the floor as possible.

The Benefits of the Locust Pose

The following are a few amazing benefits of Salabhasana:

1. This pose invigorates the entire body, stimulates the internal organs, as well as enhances the circulation of blood.
2. This asana helps to regulate the acid-base balance in the body.
3. The arms, thighs, shoulders, legs, calf muscles, and hips are strengthened through this asana.
4. The back is also toned and strengthened. This asana also encourages a healthy posture.
5. It regulates metabolism and helps you lose weight.
6. It also helps reduce stress and tension.

The Science behind the Salabhasana

The Salabhasana is said to resemble a locust at rest, but this pose is anything but a resting pose. It takes a whole lot of effort to just get into the pose, just as the grasshopper makes that jump to throw itself backward. When you practice this asana, just getting into the pose and staying there is intense. It teaches you how to focus and put your mind to work. You remain calm, yet alert.

This asana also works as a blueprint backbend, which allows you to understand the right alignment for other backbends like the Dhanurasana, the Urdhva Mukha Svanasana, and the Chakrasana.

This pose strengthens your abdomen and back. Your chest opens up as well. Your body becomes more aware of itself, and as you practice this asana, you begin to understand what is required for a balanced backbend. Your body is strengthened enough to help you with arm balancing poses, inversions, and asanas that require the engagement of the abdomen.

Usually, backbends use the limbs to push the body against gravity. But in the Salabhasana, the hands and the legs are suspended, and therefore, your back and abdomen need to work harder to lift your body.

NOTES

3.Padangustha Dhanurasana

English Name: Big Toe Bow Pose

The Padangustha dhanurasana is an important asana in yoga which is also quite beneficial. In this asana the entire body balance rests on the fingers supported by big toe. This pose follows up from the Dhanurasana or the bow pose where your body is bent like a bow. From dhanurasana you slowly raise your legs upward and then slowly remove the grip from the ankle region and then hold the grip with the fingers on the big toes. It is an intermediate level pose and requires some amount of practice and patience before you can master it. It is one of the most sought after asana that is practiced with lot of interest and enthusiasm by the yoga practitioners belonging to the beginner's level, intermediate level and advanced level alike. It will seem to be a difficult asana but with regular indulgence this asana is really easy to perform in any given condition, situation and circumstances. It is one of the difficult asana or posture that should be indulged with extra care with a lot of perfection to a great extent.

How to perform it

Follow the following steps in order to complete the Padangustha dhanurasana:

1. Start the pose by bringing the front body to the floor.
2. Now bend the knees and lift the shins vertical and then flex your feet and turn the feet out as much as possible.
3. Then hold on to the inner edges of the big toes with the fingers.
4. After this inhale and then lift the legs and the torso. Again exhale and then rotate the arms to point the elbows forward.
5. The next step is to wrap the fingers and thumbs around the big toes.
6. Again inhale and kick the feet up and back to capacity. Then straighten the arms.
7. Now lift the chin and look up. Hold the pose for some time, about 10 to 20 seconds and then breathe.

NOTES

8. To release the come exhale and then lower the arms and legs to the floor.

Anatomical Focus

The anatomical focuses of Padangustha dhanurasana deals with the head, neck, back, thighs, legs, feet, hips and waists to a great extent.

Therapeutic Advantages

Padangustha dhanurasana pose has numerous therapeutic advantages like it helps to cure rheumatic and arthritic pain. It also helps to cure obesity, back pain and shoulder pain, digestive problems, diabetes etc.

Benefits

There are many benefits of Padangustha dhanurasana. A few of them are as follows:

1. This asana is considered to be helpful to cure rheumatic and arthritic pain.
2. It is beneficial to cure obesity, back pain and shoulder pain.
3. It also helps to eliminate gastric problems and other digestive disorders.
4. It provides you with a good physique and body posture.
5. It is beneficial for people suffering from diabetes, asthma and bronchial disorders.
6. It helps to open up the chest region.
7. It reduces the pain in different parts of the body. It stretches and strengthens the back.
8. It strengthens and stretches the groin.
9. It improves the blood circulation.
10. It adds strength to the legs and feet.
11. It helps to maintain the body balance.
12. It improves the posture of the entire body.
13. It brings improvement in the flexibility for the body.
14. It strengthens the shoulder region.
15. It stretches and strengths the thighs.
16. It relieves the back pain.
17. It stretches the neck region.
18. It calms the brain and brings peaceful atmosphere to the mind.
19. It energies the entire body to meet the activities related to personal and professional life.
20. It refreshes the entire body.

NOTES

21. It improves digestion.
22. It relives constipation.
23. It increases the flexibility of the hips and opens it up.
24. It reduces the mental stress.
25. It also reduces the physical strain.

Contraindications and Cautions

It is to be highly noted that the Padangustha dhanurasana should only be practiced by people who are having very supple backs and are physically fit. Individuals who are suffering with weak lungs, headache, neck injuries, serious back injury, hernia and heart problems must avoid this asana. All those practitioners who don't have flexibility in their elbow and shoulder should practice this asana with extra care. It is to be remembered that you shouldn't clench your fist too loose or too tight.

Beginner's Tip

The beginners while practicing the Padangustha dhanurasana sometimes have a lot of difficulties in sustaining the lifting of the legs and torso. They are highly advised not to practice this asana by themselves. Daily or regular practice can make the practitioners perfect in this posture. It is to be remembered that there are high chances of hurting oneself in this posture if it is not performed rightly. One can lift the upper torso by gently pushing the hands just against the ground. All the beginners of this particular asana or posture are advised to take the assistance of a vast experienced partner in the yoga session. They can initially start the posture with their hands firmly resting on the ground, just a little bit back from the shoulders but much closer to the waist. It is to be noted that in self-indulgence, there are lot of chance of harming yourself. There is a certain amount of risk involved in the indulgence of this particular asana.

Variations

The variation of the Padangustha dhanurasana can be achieved through Trikonasana, Ardha Salabhasana or Half Locust Pose, Ardhamatsyendrasana Vajrasana, Paschimottasana and Makarasana.

Modifications and Props

In case you feel some pinching sensation while doing this pose in the lower back or sacrum then back off or rest for some time and then re-enter the position by focusing on the elongation of the spine. Also ensure that your knees are in a comfortable pose and that your feet are strongly flexed. This makes it easier to perform the pose.

NOTES

Partnering

A partner has a major role in supporting the yoga practitioners in perfectly performing the Padangustha dhanurasana. The partner can encourage you when things are done correctly. They can catch you when you are about to fall to the ground. The presence of a partner in the yoga session make you feel that you are performing in a group. A partner can help you to perform each and every steps of this asana with a lot of perfection in a right manner. A partner can correct you when things are done wrong. On the other hand, a partner can assist the beginner to get a better feel for the work in the back portion of the upper arms. Have your partner just stand straddling at your torso while you indulge in this posture. A partner is the best judge to observe whether you are performing the given steps of this particular asana correctly.

SURYA NAMASKAR

1. Surya Namaskar Postures (12 Counts)

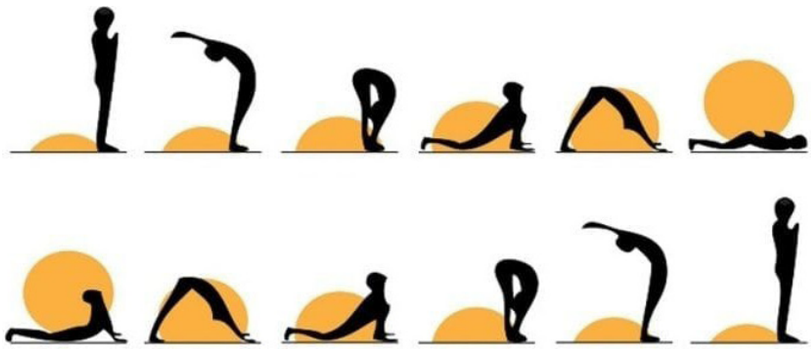
Surya Namaskar also known as **Sun Salute** or **Salute to the Sun**, is an all-time favourite of many yogis. It is a very systematic technique which combines the **twelve asanas** in a yoga sequence. Its root is in India where there are many Hindu worshippers of Surya who is the Sun deity.

Why Perform Surya Namaskar in the Morning?

It is very ideal to execute the **Sun Salutations** during sunrise and there is science about it. According to the ancient Indian sages and saints, there are Devas or divine impulses that rule the different parts of the human body.

Surya Namaskar can help you learn how to internalize the sun as part of your body system. The Surya Namaskar's design with the twelve postures can help the twelve sun cycles become in sync with your physical cycles.

The solar plexus is the central point of the human body. It is behind the navel and connects with the Sun. This is the primary reason why many yoga masters suggest the practice of Surya Namaskar in the morning. The consistent performance of this method can boost the solar plexus. As a result, vitality, confidence, ingenuity, instinctive and mental abilities increase.



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12 Surya Namaskar Steps

The **Sun Salutation** can be a very good workout for the cardiovascular during a fast pace. On the other hand, it can be very relaxing and reflective when yoga postures are executed at a slower pace. Nonetheless, it is enjoyable to perform salute to the sun either way. Your body will surely stretch and become flexible with regular practice.

Here are the Surya Namaskar steps that you should practice every morning with tips on how to deepen into the pose.

1. Step 1: Prayer pose – Pranamasana

Execution:

- Stand at the end of your mat, keep your feet together and distribute your weight on both feet equally.
- Open your chest and just relax your shoulders.
- Breathe in and lift both your arms up from the sides.
- Exhale and bring your palms together in a prayer position in front of your chest.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Activate your feet and stand as if they are tripods.
- Activate your legs and keep your spine erect.

2. Step 2: Raised arms pose – Hastauttanasana

Execution:

- Breath in and lift your arms up and back.
- Make sure that your biceps are close to your ears.
- Make effort to stretch your whole body starting from the heels up to the finger tips.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Push the pelvis forward just a little bit.
- Instead of bending backwards, reach up with fingers.

3. Step 3: Hand to foot pose –Padhastasana

Execution:

- Breathing out and bend forward from your waist while keeping your spine straight.

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- Exhale and completely bring your hands down to the floor beside your feet.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Bend your knees to bring your palms down to the floor.
- Make a moderate effort to straighten your knees.
- Keep your hands motionless in this position.
- Never move them until you compete this third sequence.

4. Step 4: Equestrian pose- Ashwa Sanchalanasana

Execution:

- Breath in and bring your right leg forward in between the two hands.
- Push your left leg as far back as possible.
- Bring your left knee to the floor and slowly look up.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Check if your right foot is exactly in between the palms.

5. Step 5: Mountain pose – Parvatasana

Execution:

- Breathing out and lift your hips as well as your tail bone up.
- Put your chest downwards to create an inverted V pose.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Keep your heels on the ground as possible.
- Make a moderate effort to lift your tailbone up.
- Gradually go deeper into the stretch.

6. Step 6: Salute with eight parts or points – Ashtanga Namaskara

Execution:

- Gradually bring your knees down to the floor then exhale.
- Slightly take your hips back and slide forward.
- Relax your chest and chin on the ground.
- Elevate your posterior a little bit.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- The eight parts of your body including two hands, two feet, two knees, chest and chin should touch the ground.

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7. Step 7: Cobra pose – Bhujangasana

Execution:

- Slide forward and raise your chest up into the Cobra pose.
- Keep your elbows bent and fixed in this pose.
- Keep your shoulders away from your ears.
- Slowly look up.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Inhale and make a moderate effort to push your chest forward.
- Exhale and make a light effort to push your navel down.
- Tuck your toes under.
- Make sure that you are stretching just as much as you can and do not go beyond the limits of your body.

8. Step 8: Mountain pose – Parvatasana

Execution:

- Breath out and lift your hips as well as your tail bone up.
- Put your chest downwards to create an inverted V pose.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Keep your heels on the ground as possible.
- Make a moderate effort to lift your tailbone up.
- Gradually go deeper into the stretch.

9. Step 9: Equestrian pose- Ashwa Sanchalanasana

Execution:

- Breath in and bring your left leg forward in between the two hands.
- Push your right leg as far back as possible.
- Bring your right knee down to the ground.
- Press your hips down then look up.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Place your left foot exactly between the two palms.
- Make sure that your left calf is perpendicular to the ground.
- You only need moderate effort in order to push your hips down towards the floor and deepen the yoga stretch.

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10. Step 10: Hand to foot pose – Padhastasana

Execution:

- Breathing out and bring your left foot forward.
- Keep your palms on the ground.
- You can bend your knees, if you feel some discomfort.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Gently straighten your knees and if you can, try and touch your nose to the knees.
- Keep on breathing.

11. Step 11: Raised Arms Pose- Hastauttanasana

Execution:

- Breath in and roll your spine up,
- Make your hands go up and bend backwards a little bit
- Push your hips slightly outward.

Yoga Stretch Deepening Tip:

- Make sure that your biceps are beside your ears.
- Aim to stretch up more instead of stretching backwards.

12. Step 12: Prayer pose – Pranamasana

Execution:

- Stand at the end of your mat, keep your feet together and distribute your weight on both feet equally.
- Open your chest and just relax your shoulders.
- Breathe in and lift both your arms up from the sides.
- Exhale and bring your palms together in a prayer position in front of your chest.

2.Surya Namskar (10 counts)

This type of surya namaskara is performed rapidly with 10 steps. It is helpful in building up the stamina and balancing the Prana.

In 10 steps – Dynamics Suryanamskara –the 5th and 9th stages are omitted.

Starting position (Sthiti): Tadasana

Stand erect with legs together. Bring the palms together to Namaskara Mudra.

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Practice

Step 1

Take the hands above the head while breathing in and bend the trunk backwards.

Step 2

- Bend forward while breathing out and touch the forehead to the knees.
- Keep the palms on the floor on either side of the legs.

Step 3

- Breathe in and kick the right leg back and rest on the toes.
- Push the buttocks forward and downwards so that the left leg is at right angle to the ground.
- Look up.

Step 4

- Breathe out and take the left leg back, resting only on palms and toes.
- Keep the body straight from head to toes inclined to the ground at about 30o.
- Take care to maintain the position of the neck in line with the back.

Step 5

- Without shifting the position of the hands and toes, inhale and glide the body forwards.
- While breathing out, rest the forehead, chest, palms, knees and toes on the ground.
- Raise the buttocks off the ground.
- Note that 8 points of body are in contact with the ground; hence the name Sastanga Namaskara (Salutation with 8 parts).

Step 6

- Breathe in and raise the trunk, making the spine concave upwards without shifting the position of the hands and feet.
- Arch the back as far as you can until the elbows are straight.
- Keep the knees off the ground.

Step 7

While exhaling, without shifting the position of hands and feet raise the buttocks, push the head down until the heels touch the ground.

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Step 8

Inhale and bring the right leg in between the two hands. Arch the back, making concavity upwards as in step 3 until the right leg is at right angle to the ground.

Step 9

- Breathe out and bring the left foot forward next to the right foot and touch the knees by the forehead as in step 2.

Step 10

- Breathe in and come back to the starting position (Sthiti).
- This completes one round of surya namaskara.

For the finishing, lie down and relax your entire body in a Yoga Nidra. Your body needs sufficient time to adjust to the effects of the stretches of your sun salutations. It can bring enough rest for the mind and body.

Surya Namaskar Benefits

Surya Namaskar is very much idyllic for very busy people who are juggling work, family and fitness program. Young and old can practice this yoga for many health benefits as well as for ensuring great well-being.

1. Good for Weight Management

Yes, many people want to lose weight. It is a very good news that there's an inexpensive way to do that! You can definitely lose extra calories simply by stretching the abdominal muscles. It can help regulate the hormonal secretions in the thyroid gland which is responsible for weight. Easy childbirth, increase of breastmilk production, zero constipation, healthy skin glow, ageless face and regular menstrual cycles are possible with the help of Surya Namaskar yoga sequence. It is indeed beneficial for women. It can help literally shed fat in areas such as hips, thighs, abdomen, chin and neck.

1. Cognitive Skills Booster

Sun salutations are also great for kids in order to improve concentration and calm the mind. It can help revitalize the nervous systems which is consist of brain and spinal cord.

2. Balance of your Dosha

The Salute to the Sun can help balance the three doshas Pita, Kapha and Vata. These constitutions may go out of balance due to varying factors. The weather, food, day-to-day activities, stress management at work and hours of sleep can all affect the dosha. However, with regular practice of Surya Namaskar, you can actually keep your dosha in balance.

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3. Good Maintenance of Over-all Health

Surya Namaskar is beneficial for the lungs and can help decrease any chances of getting tuberculosis. It can help improve the blood circulations so as to prevent blood pressure issues and palpitation. Moreover, it can correct any problems in the functioning of different glands. Believe it or not but it can increase your longevity.

Enjoy your practice of Surya Namaskar. Of course, it is important to do some gentle warm-ups before practicing. Perform your sun salutations in the east direction in the morning and in the west direction if you are executing it in the evening.

Keep some sense of gratitude and smile on your face while doing your Salute to the Sun yoga sequences. Most importantly, it is vital to remember that you need to have grace, perform it at a slow pace and do it with awareness on your breath. Your breathing should always be natural.

CULTURAL POSTURES: SITTING TYPE POSTURES

1. Paschimottanasana

Sanskrit: पश्चिमोत्तासन;

English Name: Seated Forward Bend, or Intense Dorsal Stretch (Paschima – West/Back, Uttana – Intense Stretch, Asana – Pose)

Pronounced As – POSH-ee-moh-tan-AHS-anna

This seemingly simple asana is a classic Hatha Yoga pose that has many benefits. The Paschimottanasana covers a whole lot of systems in the body and is particularly useful for diabetes and high blood pressure. This asana also gives the entire body a good stretch. Interestingly, the front part of the body is called the East, and the back is usually called the West. This asana concentrates on the back of the body, and, therefore, it is named as such. In English, this asana is called the Seated Forward Bend or the Intense Dorsal Stretch.

What You Should Know Before You Do the Asana

You must make sure to keep your stomach and bowels empty before you practice this asana. Have your meals at least four to six hours before you do the asana so that your food gets digested and there is enough energy for you to expend during the practice.

It is best to practice yoga first thing in the morning. But in the event you cannot work out in the morning, it is alright to practice it in the evening.

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Level: Basic

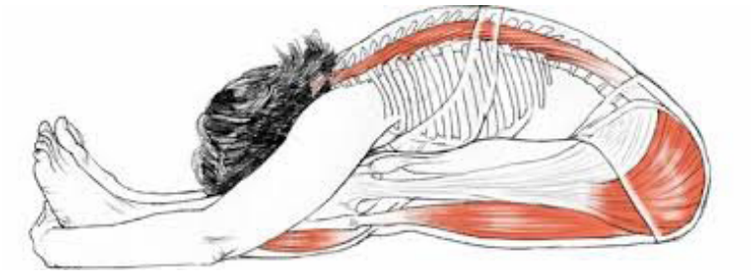
Style: Hatha Yoga

Duration: 30 – 60 seconds

Repetition: None

Stretches: Vertebral column, Shoulders, Hamstrings

Strengthens: Back, Spine



How To Do The Paschimottanasana

- Sit erect, with your legs, stretched out in front of you. Make sure that your toes are flexed towards you.
- Inhale and raise your arms over your head. Stretch.
- Exhale and bend forward. Feel the fold from your hip joints. Your chin should move towards your toes.
- Stretch out your arms, and let them reach the furthest they can, possibly till your toes. But make sure that you don't stretch too far.
- Inhale. Then, lifting your head slightly, elongate your spine.
- Exhale and move your navel towards your knees.
- Repeat this a few times. Then, place your head on your legs, and hold the pose.
- Inhale and come up back to the sitting position with your arms stretched out.
- Exhale and lower your arms.

Precautions and Contraindications

These are a few points of caution you must keep in mind before you do this asana.

- Avoid this asana if you have asthma or diarrhoea.
- In case you have a back injury, you must make sure to practice this asana only under the guidance of a certified yoga instructor.
- Pregnant women must avoid practicing this asana.

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Beginner's Tip

As a beginner, you must remember never to push yourself if you are not comfortable in a forward bend. This is more important if the asana entails sitting on the floor. When you move forward, and you feel that the space between your navel and pubis is reducing, stop, lift yourself a little, and continue moving forward. As a beginner, your tight leg muscles might make it difficult for you to bend too much, and it might look like you are sitting. It's alright. With practice, your body will become far more flexible.

Advanced Pose Alteration

To increase the stretch while you are in this asana, you need to re-extend your elbows. To do this, once you are in the asana, you must clasp your hands around the soles of your feet. You could also turn the back of one hand to the sole, and grip the wrist with the other hand.

The Benefits of The Seated Forward Bend

These are some amazing benefits of Paschimottanasana:

- This asana calms the mind and also relieves mild depression and stress.
- The shoulders, spine, and hamstrings get a good stretch.
- The kidneys, liver, uterus, and ovaries are activated.
- Practicing this asana regularly helps improve digestion.
- Menopause and menstrual discomfort can be combatted with this asana.
- Anxiety, headaches, and fatigue are reduced.
- High blood pressure, insomnia, infertility, and sinusitis can be cured with this asana.
- Paschimottanasana is said to cure diseases, increase appetite, and reduce obesity.
- This asana works particularly well for women after they have delivered a child.

The Science Behind the Paschimottanasana

This asana gives the back part of the body a good stretch, all the way from the ankles to the head. The muscles of the anterior part of the body are contracted, and this creates pressure on the abdomen and thorax, thereby, improving respiratory functions and the functioning of the intra-abdominal glands, specifically focusing on secretions. The flexibility in the lumbar region, the thighs, and the hips is improved. There is an enhancement in the circulation of the blood in the back, and the nerves of the spinal cord are toned. This asana also helps reduce fat in the hips, thighs, and abdomen region. This asana purifies the Nadis and also stimulates the Kundalini Shakti.

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2. Ustrasana

English Name: Camel Pose

Ustrasana, full camel pose, is highly recommended pose because it makes our body fit. Regular practice of this pose helps you improve the core strength, gain stamina, and make your hip and shoulder flexible. It is the modification of ardha-ustrasana. It is a very deep backward bend you perform in kneeling position. Beginning with Vajrasana, you will first widen your knees and legs and then stand on your knees, push the hips with your palms and get into ardha-ustrasana and modify it. From the ardha-ustrasana position, you will stretch your arms first and then one at a time remove the palms from your hip and press them on your respective heels. Now push your chest by arching the back, bend your head backwards and hold this position for 30 seconds to one minute. Breathe deep and slow while in this position. Your pulse rate will increase considerably. People with low or high blood pressure, insomnia, migraine, low back or neck injury should not try Ustrasana. If you have joint related issues or undergone a knee surgery in recent past – don't begin Ustrasana too early. Don't do this pose if you have lower back pain – either mild or severe – this will increase the pain. If you are physically fit and confident, you can do this asana - but on your own range of limits and abilities. People with any medical concerns should consult the doctor before practicing the exercise.

Getting into Camel Pose

1. Get into Ardha-Ustrasana.
2. Lengthen your back pelvis and draw the tailbone towards the pubis with your hands.
3. Inhale and press the shoulder blades to the back of your ribs to lift your heart.
4. Arc your back.
5. Remove your palms from the hips and press them against your heels – do this one at a time so you don't lose balance. You can slightly tilt the thighs backwards while touching the heel and again press them back

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to perpendicular to floor after joining the hand and heel. If necessary, turn your toes under and raise the heels.

6. Turn the arms outward, the elbow creases should face forward.
7. Arch your back – your arms should be straight.
8. Drop your head back. You may also keep it at a neutral position. Don't strain the neck or tighten the throat.
9. Breathe calm and deep. Maintain the position for 30 seconds to one minute.
10. To release, bring your hands back to your front hips. Inhale, lead with your heart, and lift your torso by pushing your hips down toward the floor. Your head should come up last. Rest in Child's Pose (Balasana) or Corpse Pose (Savasana).

Vajrasana - Points to remember

1. You may feel pain in the legs when you begin to practice this asana. If your leg aches, undo the asana and stretch your legs. Now massage your ankles, knees and calf muscles with hand. This soothes the muscles and pain gradually fades.
2. If you have knee problem, have history of knee injury or had recent knee surgery; don't practice Vajrasana.
3. You can still practice this asana if you are pregnant. Be cautious to keep your knees apart to not stress your abdomen.

Benefits of Camel Pose

- Ustrasana stretches chest, abdomen, quadriceps, and hip flexors.
- Improves spinal flexibility; strengthens shoulders and back muscles, thighs and arms; tones organs of abdomen, pelvis and neck; reduces fat on thighs; loosens up the vertebrate; opens up the hips; and improves posture.
- Energizes the body, reduces anxiety and fatigue.
- Stimulates endocrine glands, kidneys and digestive system stretching the abdomen and also curse constipation.
- Stimulates and improves respiratory and nervous systems by proper blood circulation.
- Activates thyroid glands.
- Ustrasana helps to heal and balance the chakras

3.Ardha Matsyendrasana

English Name: Half Lord of The Fish Pose

Pronunciation: ar-DHUH mutts-YEN-drah-suh-nuh

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Ardha Matsyendrasana, also known as the Half Lord of The Fish pose, Half Spinal Twist Pose, is derived from the Sanskrit.

Ardha matsyendrasana, a seated twist pose, is the ninth of the 12 basic poses in Hatha yoga. The name for this asana is derived from the Sanskrit, *'ardha',* meaning half; *'matsya',* meaning fish; '*indra'* meaning king; and '*asana'* meaning pose.

To enter the pose, the yogi begins in *dandasana* (staff pose). The left foot is bent so it rests on the outside of the right thigh. The right foot slides as close as possible to the left buttock. The right elbow is placed on the outer side of the left knee with the hand pointed upward, creating a twist in the body. This is repeated on the opposite side.

Ardha Matsyendrasana is one of the best twisting postures. The entire spine gets rotated around its axis. Moreover, your spine also gets two side twists throughout its length. The levers used for these extreme twists are the arms and the knees.

Steps to perform Ardha Matsyendrasana:

- Sit with an extended spine and your legs extended out in front.
- Bend your right knee and cross your foot over your left thigh.
- Bend your left knee and bring your left heel to your outer right hip. Keep your right foot on the inside of your left knee if your right foot lifts off the floor.
- Place your right fingertips on the floor next to your right hip, and inhale as you elongate your spine.
- Hold the extension and exhale as you twist towards the right, rotating from your back left ribs. Use the twisting action itself to go deeper; avoid hooking your elbow right away and using the arm for leverage. Instead, wrap your left arm lightly around your knee while lengthening with each inhale. Exhale to twist more.

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- Bring your elbow outside your knee. Allow your arms to maintain the length of your spine, despite the urge to collapse due to the pressure of the elbow against your knee.
- You can turn your head to the right if that feels comfortable.

Health Benefits of Ardha Matsyendrasana:

- Increases the elasticity of the spine, tones the spinal nerves and improves the functioning of the spinal cord.
- Stretches the muscles on one side of the body whilst compressing the muscles on the other side.
- Relieves back pain and stiffness from between the vertebrae.
- Useful for slipped disc.
- Massages the abdominal organs and increases the digestive juices making it useful for loss of appetite and constipation.
- Useful for diabetics, with concentration on the pancreas.
- Regulates the secretion of bile and adrenaline.
- Relieves tension that may have built up in the back from forward and back bending asanas.
- Opens the chest and increases the oxygen supply to the lungs.
- Loosens the hip joints, relieving stiffness.
- Releases tension in the arms, shoulders, upper back and neck.
- Increases purification of the blood as well as the internal organs.
- Improves round shoulders

4. Mayurasana

Sanskrit: मयूरासन;

English Name: Mayur – Peacock, Asana – Pose;

Pronounced As: my-yer-ahs-anna

According to the Hindu texts, the peacock symbolizes love and immortality. This asana is said to resemble a peacock when it struts around with its feathers down. The Peacock Pose has a whole lot of benefits, and although it looks complicated, with a little practice, it is quite easy to do.

What You Should Know Before You Do the Asana

You must make sure to keep your stomach and bowels empty before you practice this asana. Have your meals at least four to six hours before you do the asana so that your food gets digested, and there is enough energy for you to expend during the practice.

NOTES

It is best to practice yoga first thing in the morning. But in the event you cannot work out in the morning, it is alright to practice it in the evening

Level: Basic/ Intermediate

Style: Hatha Yoga

Duration: 30 to 60 seconds

Repetition: None

Stretches: Arms, Back

Strengthens: Forearms, Legs, Wrists, Back Torso

How To Do The Mayurasana (Peacock Pose)

1. Begin by sitting on your heels. Make sure your knees are wide apart.
2. Place your hands on the floor, and let your fingers point towards your body. Gently bend your elbows and press them towards your abdomen.
3. You must keep your belly firm. To do this, drop your head on the floor, and work up the strength in your stomach.
4. Stretch your legs out, such that your knees are straight, and the upper part of your feet are facing the floor.
5. Your shoulder blades must be firm and pushed into your back. Tighten your buttocks and raise your head. Set your gaze forward.
6. Shift your body weight forward and lift your legs off the floor. Your body must be lifted with the weight on the hands. It should be parallel to the floor.
7. Hold the pose for about 10 seconds initially. With practice, you should be able to hold it for up to one minute.
8. To release, drop your head and feet on the ground. Relax.

Precautions and Contraindications

These are a few points of caution you must keep in mind before you do this asana.

- It is best to avoid this asana if you have an injury in your wrist, shoulder or elbow.

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- Avoid this asana in case you have the following conditions:
  i. Heart diseases
  ii. Hernia
  iii. High blood pressure
  iv. Eye, ear, and nose infections
  v. Problems in the intestine
  vi. Brain tumor
  vii. Menstruation
  viii. Pregnancy
- This asana is said to detoxify your system and release toxins. If you feel unwell during the pose, release the asana immediately.

Benefits of The Peacock Pose

These are some amazing benefits of Mayurasana:

- The *Gheranda Samhita* (one of the three classic books on Hatha Yoga) says that the Peacock Pose cancels toxins. It detoxifies the body and also helps to get rid of tumors and fevers.
- It helps tone the digestive organs and increases blood circulation in the abdominal area, therefore making it stronger.
- This asana energizes the pancreas, stomach, liver, spleen, kidneys, and intestines.
- It also helps fight diabetes and piles.
- This asana strengthens and tones the reproductive system, therefore reducing all menstrual and menopause dysfunctions. It also improves sexual activity.
- It helps to make the shoulders, elbows, wrist, and spine stronger.
- It helps improve posture.
- This asana calms the mind and reduces stress and anxiety.
- It improves concentration as well as coordination between the mind and the body.

The Science Behind the Mayurasana

When you look at how this asana is done, you might feel that all you need is arm strength. But the real secret behind mastering this pose lies in your belly.

Just like the other arm balancing poses, this asana also needs you to be incredibly strong. But along with strength, you also need patience because only with practice will you be able to develop that relationship with gravity that is required to master this pose. To do that, you need to have a good

foundation, which will include working of your forearms, hands, and belly. You will have to consider your arms as your legs and push your elbows into your belly. This might be uncomfortable initially, but this is what you need to finish this pose with perfection. When you do this, you will notice your abdominal muscles strengthen under your abs. This strength will give you stability in the pose

5. Sirsasana

English Name: Head Stand pose

A number of people are apprehensive and disinterested to do Sirsasana (Headstand) because of its headstand position and requires some sort of balance. In fact, it is not difficult to practice if it is performed under the guidance of an expert and providing the basic rules are carefully followed. The brain needs well oxygenated blood for performing its various functions smoothly. However, in case of sedentary as well as general people, the brain does not receive sufficient enriched oxygenated blood that leads to headache, pituitary malfunctioning, diabetes, sexual problems, improper vision, hair fall, skin conditions, piles, varicose vein, etc.

Sirsasana also prevents blood stagnation in the lower parts of the body thus ensures homogenous blood supply to the entire parts of the body. The scientific experiment has verified that the amount of air breathed per minute during the performance of headstand yoga was considerably reduced. Oxygen consumption by the tissues increased and the amount of oxygen exhaled was less, indicating that the transfer of oxygen to the blood is greatly increased. It has been also shown that the number of WBC has increased thus prevents the body from infections and develop immunity. The ideal time to practice it is early in the morning just before breakfast.

How to do Headstand Yoga

Mastering Sirsasana is not a difficult task. Here are the 10 simple and easy steps are being enumerated to raise the body into the final pose and how to become mastered for headstand yoga. Once this is achieved then staying in the final pose is little difficulty.

- Interlock the fingers tightly, palms forming a cup.
- Place the head on the formed cup so that the crown of the head touches the palms.
- Raise the knees from the floor by pulling the toes towards the head. Slowly raise your legs upwards from the floor.
- After the body gets properly balanced in this position, gradually and slowly straighten the legs.
- Take care that you maintain equilibrium and you don't fall backwards

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- Make sure that the spine and thighs are in line, straight and vertical.
- Relax the whole body as much as possible.
- Close the eyes
- Breathe slowly and deeply.
- This is the final pose of sirsasana. Stay in the final pose for a comfortable length of time. Come back by flexing the knees and sliding them down to the floor in reverse order.

Top Benefits of Sirsasana

- Sirsasana supplies an enriched oxygenated blood to the brain cells thus provide nourishment to the billions of brain cells.
- It helps to rejuvenate, revitalize and increases the effectiveness of brain cells.
- It induces calmness thus prevents headache and migraine.
- It controls various types of glandular and nervous disorders related with pituitary glands.
- The pose has a significant positive influence in relieving diabetes. It acts directly on the pituitary gland by improving the blood supply thus has been great help in combating diabetes.
- It is extremely beneficial in combating sexual disorders such as prostrate problems hydrocele, leucorrhea, spermatorrhea, and all general menopausal and menstrual ailments.
- It acts upon the thyroid gland and helps to balance the metabolic functions.
- It improves the functions of the sensory organs by ensuring adequate supply of blood to these organs.
- The conditions like myopia, astigmatism and catarrh and general bad hearing are found to be improved by regular practice of it.
- It allows an oxygen rich flow of blood to the facial skin thus improves the facial complexion.
- It is good to prevent hair fall, baldness and greying of hair by supplying enriched blood and nutrients to the scalp region.
- People suffering from loss of sleep, memory and vitality have recovered by the regular practice of this asana.
- It relieves from colds, coughs, tonsillitis, halitosis and palpitations.
- RBC formation also increased after the regular practice of it.

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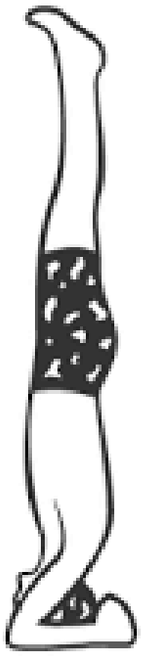


Headstand Yoga Precautions

The following precautions should be observed while performing Sirsasna.

- Keep the whole-body vertical in the final pose; don't incline backwards, forwards or sideways.
- Try to relax as many muscles as possible in the final position.
- Try to ensure that most of the weight of the body is supported on the head in the final position not in the arms.
- One should practice this yoga pose just after doing other asanas.
- Practice it before Pranayama and meditative yoga pose.
- A person suffering from high blood pressure, heart malfunctioning, cerebral or coronary thrombosis, arteriosclerosis, conjunctivitis and chronic glaucoma, blood hemorrhage in the head, Otia, chronic catarrh, slipped disc and kidney problems, should not practice sirsasana.
- In case of extremely impure blood, the impurities could be directed into the brain.
- It also shouldn't perform when your bowels are extremely full, feeling physically tired, and having headache or migraine.
- Practicing it should be avoided after intense physical exercise as vigorous workout releases toxins in the body that may reach to the brain.

NOTES

- During pregnancy or menstruation.
- Sirsasna should be immediately stopped if you experience a headache, feel dizziness, perspire profusely, become very hot, have palpitation of the heart.

Sirsasana duration

The duration for practicing of the headstand pose varies from person to person. A person who is performing this pose for years can practice for up to 30 minutes. For the beginners, 30 second is good and the maintaining time may be increased up to 5 minutes under the guidance of an expert.

Counterpose

After performing sirsasana, the counterpose is utmost important to smooth the various body functions. The different simple yoga poses that can be performed just after practicing headstand yoga are Tadasana and Shavasana. The stick asana can also be performed. Massaging the body is also one of the options.

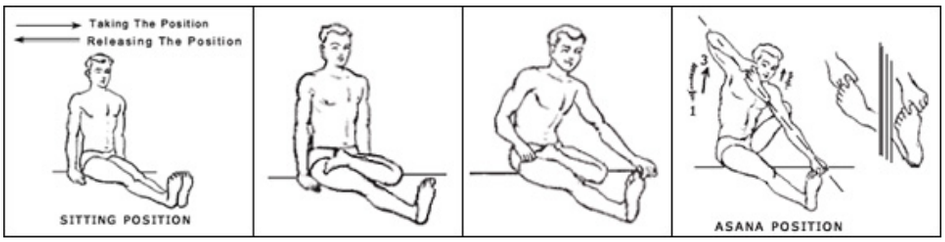
Headstand yoga side effects

While doing sirsasana, the practitioner should be relaxed and calm to avoid contradictory results

6. Akarna Dhanurasana Type 1

English name: *Shooting Bow Pose*

Meaning: Bow Pose In Sitting



Posture:

In this asana, the body is stretched more like a string of bow when pulled at the time of archery.

Procedure:

- Bend the left leg in knee and keep the foot on the thigh of right leg. Keep the right leg straight.
- Hold the big toe of the left leg with right hand, hold it between the thumb and index finger and other 3 fingers to have a good grip of the thumb. Hold big toe of the right leg with left hand.

NOTES

- Exhale and inhaling start lifting the left foot with the right hand and pull it up to ear. Keep the trunk and neck erect and the sight fixed on the other end of the left hand.
- Continue normal breathing.

Position:

While trying to raise the foot up to ear, one tends to bend neck. But this is wrong, initially it may be difficult but it does not matter. Only care should be taken to keep the neck and trunk straight. Try to pull up the foot as much as possible.

Releasing:

- Inhale and exhaling, start bringing the foot down and place it on the thigh.
- Restore the hands to their place.
- Take the left foot to original position.

Duration:

This asana exerts great strain and one can't maintain it for long but with practice one can maintain it for up to 30 seconds.

Internal effects:

In this asana, great strain is exerted on hand, legs and joints of waist and the knees. Consequently, the efficiency of the organs increases.

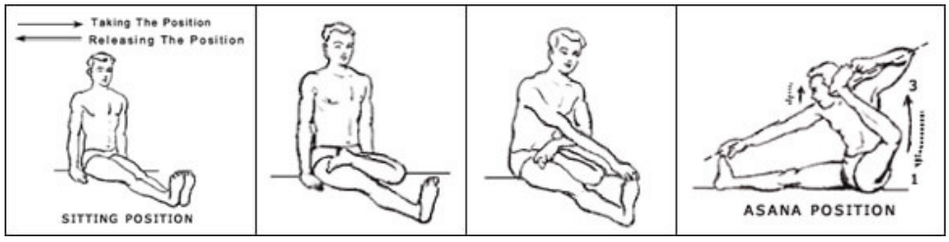
Precaution:

One should avoid the temptation of attaining the ideal position if strain is unbearable.

7.Akarna Dhanurasana Type 2

Sanskrit name: Akarna Dhanurasana type 2

Meaning: bow pose in sitting



Posture

This Asana involves another system of pulling the leg which gives the impression of a bow with an arrow to be shot and hence, the name Dhanurasana.

Pre-Position

Sitting Position.

Procedure

- Bend the left leg in knee and keep the foot on the thigh of right leg. Keep the right leg straight.
- Hold the big toe of the left leg with left hand, and that of the right leg with the right hand.
- Exhale, and inhaling start lifting the left leg with the left hand and pull it up to the left ear and stabilize it at that point.
- Continue normal breathing.

Position

When one leg is lifted, the other leg and hand should be kept straight. The sight should be fixed on the other end of the straight hand. Once the Asana Position is taken, smooth breathing should continue.

Releasing

- Inhale, and exhaling bring the left leg on the thigh of the right leg.
- Restore both the hands to their place.
- Straighten the left leg and take the sitting position.

Note: Do this asana in the above-mentioned manner by taking up the right leg on the thigh of the left leg bringing in relevant changes in the position.

Duration

This latter Asana exerts more strain than the former. It should also be maintained for thirty seconds to experience its benefits.

Internal Effects

In this asana the direction of strain is towards the joints of the waist.

Precaution

The person with weak waist joints should not do this asana as it brings great strain to the joints.

NOTES

8.Yoga Dandasana

English name: Staff Pose

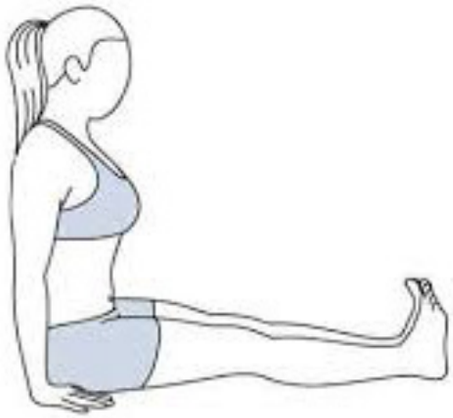
Sanskrit: दण्डासन; Danda – Stick, Asana – Pose;

Pronounced As: dahn-dah-sah-nah

Dandasana is a simple seated posture with the legs straight in front of the body and the spine upright and long. The name comes from the Sanskrit *danda* which means "stick" or "staff" and *asana* which means "posture" or "seat." It is an exercise that will help your body prepare itself for the more intense poses. It also increases your ability to work on aligning your body perfectly.

It is a posture which requires a great deal of awareness and presence to hold and, as such, is considered good for becoming more mindful and focused in one's yoga practice. It also prepares the body and mind for other seated postures.

The English name for dandasana is staff pose



What You Should Know Before You Do The Asana

This asana is a sort of warm-up pose for the deeper yoga poses. You must make sure to keep your stomach and bowels empty before you practice this asana. Make sure you have your meals at least four to six hours before you do the asana so that your food gets digested, and there is enough energy for you to expend during the practice.

It is best to practice yoga in the morning. But in the event if you cannot work out in the morning, it is alright to practice it in the evening.

Level: Beginner

Style: Vinyasa

Duration: 20 to 30 seconds

NOTES

Repetition: None

Stretches: Shoulders, Thorax

Strengthens: Back

How To Do Dandasana

- Sit erect on the ground, with your back straightened and your legs stretched out in front of you. Your legs must be parallel to each other, and feet should be pointed upwards.
- Press your buttocks on the floor and align your head in such a way that the crown faces the ceiling. This will automatically straighten and lengthen your spine.
- Flex your feet and press your heels.
- Place your palms next to your hips on the floor. This will support your spine and also relax your shoulders. Your torso must be straight, but relaxed.
- Relax your legs and ground the lower half of your body firmly to the floor.
- Breathe normally and hold the pose for about 20 to 30 seconds.

Precautions and Contraindications

These are some points of caution you must keep in mind before you practice this asana.

- It is best to avoid this asana if you have a lower back or a wrist injury.
- Although this is a fairly simple pose, it is best to do it under the supervision of a yoga instructor. When you practice yoga, remember to listen to your body and push only as much as it can endure.

Benefits of The Staff Pose

These are some amazing benefits of Dandasana:

- This asana helps to strengthen the muscles on your back.
- It also helps to stretch the chest and the shoulders.
- With regular practice of this asana, your posture is sure to be improved.
- The abdomen is stretched and strengthened as well.
- It is known to cure sciatica and asthma.
- This asana helps to focus and calm the mind. When paired with proper breathing, it relieves stress and helps enhance concentration.

NOTES

The Science Behind Dandasana

However easy this pose might look, it is quite an intense, strength-building exercise for the chest, abdomen, and upper back.

This pose is the foundation for all seated poses as it gives the basic structure for them all. If you look closely, it is the seated version of the Tadasana or Mountain Pose.

9. Kukkutasana

English Name: Cock or Rooster Pose

In Sanskrit Kukkut means Cock or Rooster and Asana means sit, Pose or Posture. Kukkutasana or cock Pose is named so since it looks like a cock. The name comes from the Sanskrit *kukkuta,* meaning "rooster," and *asana,* meaning "pose" or "posture." Therefore, kukkutasana is also referred to as rooster pose in English.

Cock or rooster yoga pose has been said in antiquated sacred yoga texts like the *Gheranda Samhita* and *Hatha Yoga Pradeepika*. It is a difficult pose that requirements arms power to be completed well. practice well Tulasana and Bakasana before doing Kukkutasana.

Like other asanas, it is important that your stomach is empty when you attempt this asana. Keep a gap between in your practice and meal, at least four to six hour because this will give you ample time to process your nourishment and create vitality for your practice. Do yoga asana in the morning. In case you can't rehearse yoga in the morning, then do your practice in evening.

Kukkutasana is an advanced balancing yoga pose that requires good flexibility of the legs and benefits the arms and shoulders.

Starting in *padmasana* (lotus pose), the hands are squeezed between the thighs and calf muscles until they reach the floor. Palms are touching the floor, with the fingers spread wide and pointing forward. Putting pressure on the hands, the body is lifted above the floor, its entire weight supported by the palms alone. The pose is held for as long as is comfortable.

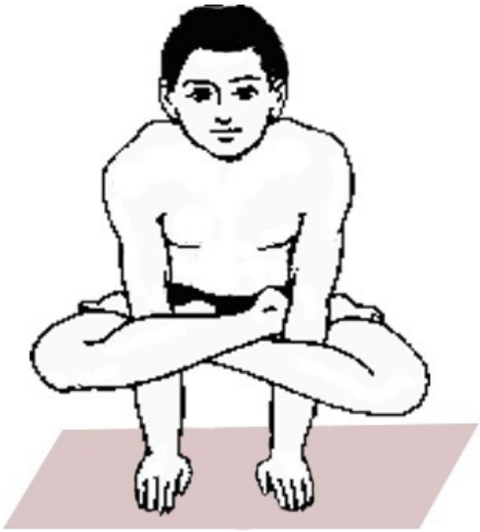
NOTES

Kukkutasana stimulates the *muladhara* chakra and is used for awakening the *kundalini shakti,* or the primal energy coiled at the base of the spine. When stimulated, laziness vanishes.

It is recommended to learn this pose only after mastering padmasana.

Steps of Kukkutasana

- First sit in the Lotus Pose (Padmasana)



- Put your arms in-between the gape of your thighs and calf muscles, and your palms should touch the ground or floor through this gape.
- Now spread out your fingers, pointing forward.
- Push your palms as much as possible. After that, breathe in while you try to lift your body.
- You have to support your body weight by your palms. By daily practice, you will gain the ability to achieve balance.
- Hold the Position for 1 to 5 minutes and breathes normally.
- Breathe out and release the pose and get back to the ground.
- As per your convenience repeat the pose as much as you can.

Benefits of Kukkutasana

- It stretches your Arms, spine and strengthens your shoulders, Elbows and wrists.
- It makes your chest broader.
- It loosens up your legs.
- It develops balance and strength furthermore increases your concentration level.

- The perineum contracts amid this asana, in this manner, the muscles are reinforced.
- It enacts and manages the Muladhara Chakra.
- It invigorates your digestive system.
- It stimulates the digestive system.
- It is beneficial in menstrual discomfort and hip pain.

Tips for Beginners

As a learner or beginner, it may be difficult to get this asana right. These pointers will help you keep up the stance easily:

- Turn your look to a specific point of convergence at a separation and focus on it. This ought to help you look after equalization.
- Ensure that your back is erect. Try not to slouch while you are in this asana.
- If you think that it's difficult to slip your arms into the crevice between your collapsed legs, you could oil your limbs to make it less demanding.

Note:

This pose is an advanced one. In the event that you have lung and heart issues, broadened spleens, or gastric ulcers, abstain from doing this asana.

In the event that you are a beginner, you should rehearse it under the supervision of an accomplished yoga coach.

10. Hanuman Asana

***hanumat* = having large jaws: a monkey-chief**

Hanuman was the semi-divine chief of an army of monkeys who served the god Rama. As told in the Hindu epic, the Ramayana, Hanuman once jumped in a single stride the distance between southern India and (Sri) Lanka. This split-leg pose mimics his famous leap.

In this extreme pose, the forward-bending action in the front leg and pelvic half is countered by the backward-bending action in the back leg and pelvic half. The spine can then seek balance between those two opposing actions.

In a symmetrical forward bend like paschimottanasana, part of the action of forward bending comes from the spine, as well as the lower limbs. Similarly, in a back bend like urdhva dhanurasa (the backward-bending action comes from the lower limbs and spine together. In hanumanasana, however, the fact that the two legs are doing opposite actions means that the forward-bending and backward-bending actions are directed almost totally into the legs, making both aspects more intense.

NOTES

Because there is generally more range of motion for the hip joint in flexion than in extension, the front leg usually moves more quickly into flexion and the movement of the back leg draws the spine into extension. This is also why more work is often felt in the extensors of the front leg than in the flexors of the back leg. The action in each leg is limited by the opposite leg, making it a kind of bound pose. This limitation means that force isn't dispersed into space so much as directed into potentially vulnerable areas (hamstring attachments are especially at risk for over-mobilizing in this pose). This concern is greatly compounded if the pose is done passively.

The presence of gravity means that it isn't necessary to concentrically contract any muscles to pull the body into this position; instead, the weight of the body itself deepens the action. To do the pose safely, however, the body is not just passively releasing into gravity.

If hanumanasana is done more actively, with attention to the eccentric actions of the lengthening muscles, the mobilization of the pose can be distributed over several joints; a little movement in a lot of places can safely distribute the force. This requires awareness of your own tendencies toward places you hold or let go so that you can stabilize the mobile spots and mobilize the fixated areas.

A final note about having the legs in neutral rotation: While the position of the legs is neutral in terms of internal and external rotation, it actually takes active internal rotation to maintain this neutral position. A neutral position in the joint is not always the position with the least muscular effort, depending on the actions of gravity and the other limbs. Maintaining a neutral position can often be a quite vigorous action muscularly.

In this pose, many people let the back leg externally rotate to get it all the way down. Letting the back leg roll out puts twisting pressure into the lumbar spine and the SI joint of the back leg, not to mention a twisting pressure into the back knee. It also puts more pressure into the adductors of the back leg (adductor longus and brevis, pectineus, and gracilis) without the eccentric support of the iliacus and psoas major or rectus femoris. As a result, the groin can be over mobilized, and the usually overtight rectus femoris doesn't get as much movement as it could. It takes a different kind of discipline to resist the impulse to go as low as possible and to use props (blocks and blankets) as necessary to maintain the integrity of the pose

Monkey Pose: Step-by-Step Instructions

- Kneel on the floor. Step your right foot forward about a foot in front of your left knee and rotate your right thigh outwardly. Do this by lifting the inner sole away from the floor and resting the foot on the outer heel.

NOTES

- Exhale and lean your torso forward, pressing your fingertips to the floor. Slowly slide your left knee back, straightening the knee and at the same time descending the right thigh toward the floor. Stop straightening the back knee just before you reach the limit of your stretch.
- Now begin to push the right heel away from your torso. Because we started with a strong external rotation of the front leg, gradually turn the leg inward as it straightens to bring the kneecap toward the ceiling. As the front leg straightens, resume pressing the left knee back, and carefully descend the front of the left thigh and the back of the right leg (and the base of the pelvis) to the floor. Make sure the center of the right knee points directly up toward the ceiling.
- Also check to see that the back leg extends straight out of the hip (and isn't angled out to the side), and that the center of the back kneecap is pressing directly on the floor. Keep the front leg active by extending through the heel and lifting the ball of the foot toward the ceiling. Bring the hands into Anjali Mudra (Salutation Seal) or stretch the arms straight up toward the ceiling.
- Stay in this pose for 30 seconds to a minute. To release the posture, press your hands to the floor, turn the front leg out slightly, and slowly return the front heel and the back knee to their starting positions. Then reverse the legs and repeat for the same length of time.

The Benefits of Monkey Pose

These are some amazing benefits of the Hanumanasana:

- This asana helps to stretch as well as strengthen the muscles in the thighs, groin region, and hamstrings.
- This asana also helps to stimulate the reproductive and digestive organs, thereby improving their functioning.
- With regular practice, this asana makes the hips extremely flexible.

NOTES

- The back muscles are stretched.
- Being an intense stretch, this asana helps release stress and tension.

11. Upavistha Konasana or Ugrasana

English Name: Seated Wide Angle Forward Bend

The greatness of yoga lies in the fact that even ordinary looking poses have the capacity to fulfill many health needs. In the vast list of yogic poses, Upavistha Konasana is one such exercise that can bring physical, mental as well as spiritual strength to you. However, to derive the numerous benefits of Upavistha Konasana**,** you have to perform this pose under the able guidance of a professional instructor.

This simple looking pose called Upavistha Konasana also has its root in the Sanskrit language. Herein, Upavistha is for the 'sitting', Kona refers to 'angle', and the 'asana' means 'posture or pose.' However, if practiced regularly, this asana can open up the hips and make your inner thighs, back, and the shoulders stronger.

The Science Behind Upavistha Konasana

After performing this asana with a relatively wider stretch, your thought process, as well as the emotions, get stimulated. This type of development happens mainly due to the challenge that Upavistha Konasana throws before you. In the process of doing this asana perfectly, you actually push your mental as well as physical boundaries. Just look at any picture of this asana and you will be amazed to see that even after enduring intense pain, yogis manage to stay grounded.

NOTES

Ensure These Things Before Upavistha Konasana

Make sure to do this asana on an empty stomach. For best results, take your meal at least five hours before practicing the wide angle seated forward bend. In order to prepare for this intermediate level Hatha Yoga Style Pose, you can consider Baddha Konasana, Dandasana or Supta Padangusthasana as the preparatory poses.

How to Perform Wide Angle Seated Forward Bend Correctly?

- First of all, get a firm yoga mat for performing this pose. Begin this asana by sitting in an erect pose with your legs open and at an angle of 90 degrees.
- Now, stretch your toes as straight as you can and keep it in proper alignment with the knees. In fact, you might start getting a feel of a curve in your lower back after this stretch.
- Further, place your folded palms on the floor in such a manner that they are just behind the hips. You might have to bend a little for maintaining a perfect balance in this pose.
- Now, take a deep breath that might help in lifting the sides of your body slightly. This inhale will create a hollow space in your spine. Pay attention to your posture in this mode while holding the breath for a few seconds. You will definitely be able to experience an intense but enjoyable stretch in your legs.
- Now, you can slowly exhale by getting ample support from the lower back.
- Repeat this process of inhaling and exhaling for a few times until your spine and legs feel comfortable.
- Finally, fold your knees in a gentle manner and pull back the legs together to feel the bliss.

The Top Five Benefits of Wide Angle Seated Forward Bend

- **Strengthen the Back:** The very mechanism of this asana ensures that the inside portion of both the legs gets ample stretch. This proves extremely beneficial if you are suffering from sciatica or arthritis.
- **Fire-up the Core:** During the process of bending and then breathing effectively, the abdominal organs get toned and stimulated. This leads to a better digestive system and a toned belly.
- **Acquire Mental Peace:** One of the key benefits of benefits of Upavistha Konasana is its ability to ensure you have an extremely relaxed and calm brain. This happens due to rhythmic breathing and a proper flow of blood as a result of this asana performance.

NOTES

- **Manage Menstrual Issues with Ease:** You can also practice this asana in order to feel more at ease during menstruation. A keen performance of this pose regulates the menstrual flow and helps with making it a hassle-free process.

Despite being simple and less time-consuming, the benefits of Upavistha Konasana are more than amazing. With proper information and a relaxed approach (keeping the condition of your back in mind, particularly) you can improve the stamina of your body and be at peace in the mind

12. Janu Sirsasana

English name: Seated forward bend

Janu Sirsasana is a seated forward bend and a part of primary series of Astanga Yoga. Practicing 'Janu Sirsasana' makes the spine more flexible by stretching and expanding it during the practice. It aids digestion by toning abdominal organs and is beneficial for the well-functioning of reproductive organs.

Janu Sirsasana is also known as Ardha Paschimottanasana and can be practiced as a preparatory pose before practicing Paschimottanasana (Seated forward bend). Its name is derived from three Sanskrit words whose meaning has inspired the name 'Head to Knee Pose'.

Janu = Knee

Sirsh = Head

Asana = Comfortable seat or posture

Head-to-Knee Pose (Janu Sirsasana) is an excellent stretch to relieve tight hamstrings, the muscles in the back of your thighs. If you tend to dislike doing a seated forward bend with both legs straight, this pose may come as a pleasant surprise. Taking your stretch one leg at a time allows you to go a lot deeper and feels so much better.

Just make sure that you›re keeping your forward fold centered over your extended leg for the best results. If you want to take your torso between your open legs, that›s fine too, but it›s a different pose known as Upavistha Konasana.

NOTES

Steps to practice Janu Sirsasana (Head to knee pose)

- Sit straight with the legs stretched out in front of the body, keeping the feet together.
- Bend the left knee and bring the left heel close to your groin as much as you can comfortably. Place the sole of the left foot to the inside of right leg's inner thigh.
- Keep the left knee on the floor. Place the palm of your hands on the top of the right knee.
- Inhale and using your pelvic muscles, slowly bend the torso in the forward direction sliding your hands towards the right foot.
- Try to get a hold of right foot if possible, else keep your hands as far as you can comfortably. Ideally, hands are locked behind the sole of the right foot, grabbing the left wrist with a right hand. It takes time to be able to bend to that extent.
- Move your head towards your right leg, if possible touch your knee with your forehead.
- Keep the back relaxed and don't overstretch the body.
- Retain the final position for a few seconds or as long as you feel comfortable, breathing normally.
- To return, inhale and lift the head, release the hands and bring them back in upright position.
- Take 3 long and deep breaths. Practice again by interchanging the position of the legs.

  Practice 2-6 times by changing the position of legs each time.

Precautions for Janu Sirsasana (Head to knee pose)

The time differs from person to person to reach the final position depending on their flexibility and consistency they put into practice. Never rush or force yourself in getting into a posture.

- While moving the trunk forward use the muscles of the pelvic region first and then the spine. Initially, it won't be easy for people having a stiff body but with practice, it can be learned.
- While you bend forward reaching for the foot, expand the arms from the shoulder.
- Avoid practicing Janu Sirsasana in case you suffer from any of this condition: sciatica, slipped disc, injured knee or a hernia.

Benefits of Janu Sirshasana (Head to knee pose)

- Tones and massages the organs of the pelvic and abdominal region such as pancreas, liver, kidneys, spleen, adrenal glands and gonad glands.
- Improves digestion, remove excess fat from the pelvic and abdominal region. Increase flexibility of the hip joints.
- Gives a good stretch to the spinal column, hamstring muscles and is beneficial for the heart.
- Function as preparatory pose for meditative poses as it helps in loosening up the legs.
- Beneficial for those who suffer from insomnia, high blood pressure and sinusitis.
- Helpful in curing impotency in males

13. Kurmasana

English name: – Turtle or tortoise pose

Meaning: – Turtle or Tortoise

Preparatory Poses: – Dandasana (Staff Pose), Adho Mukha Svanasana (Downward-Facing Dog)

Sanskrit: – कूर्मासन

In Sanskrit, 'Kurma' implies Turtle or Tortoise. In this asana, your body looks similar to the tortoise in the final step of this pose on the ground. When we watch a tortoise, we see that just the hands and legs distend out from the shell. In the last position, this asana mirrors the tortoise. Kurmasana tones the whole stomach muscles evacuates paunch fat and is used for diabetes. This asana is specified in the *Gheranda Samhita*, however, the prominent adaptation rehearsed today is somewhat unique in relation to what is said in the established content.

NOTES

To perform Kurmasana you have to sit with the legs outstretched, feet as widely separated as could be expected under the circumstances. The knees are twisted marginally, keeping the heels in contact with the floor. The body is inclined forward from the hips and the hands slid under the knees. The body inclines forward (twisting at the hips) to permit the hands and arms to slide sideways and in reverse (under the knees) until the elbows lie close to the back of the knees. The heels are pushed forward and legs fixed however much as could be expected. The brow or button is conveyed to touch the floor. The arms are further taken around the back to interlock the hands under the butts. (If you are attempting this asana first time they don't interlock your hands, after 2 or 3 days you can try it. If you are unable to do that then, do this asana without interlocking your arms).

Steps of Kurmasana (Tortoise Pose)

- First, sit comfortably in Staff Pose (Dandasana) place your hands on the floor close by your hips.
- Now press your thighs into the ground or floor, your feet should flex, and try to lift your chest.
- Keep your legs to the corners of the mat; keep your knee wide as your Take a couple of breaths here.
- Now bend your knees with keeping your feet flexed.
- Place them nearer to your hips. Expand your chest in forward down and keep your arms forward down between your legs.
- Bend your legs significantly all the more, with the goal that you can put your shoulders one by one under your knees. (If this is difficult for you then keep going on with forwarding bend)
- Stretch your arms out to the sides.
- After that try to roll your thighs in the inward direction and keep your inner heels extended, without making pressure in the feet.
- Stretch the front part of your chest and collarbones in forwarding direction and keep them down with the assistance of the weight of your thighs on the shoulders or upper arms.
- Try to push inner heels down and forward to extend and straight your legs, at that moment try to keep your inner thighs in contact with your side ribs.
- Breathe in and keep on extending your arms and mid-section (chest) out to your sides.
- Breathe out to extend your spine more distant forward. Try not to constrain your legs, breathe out and relax to release the pose.

NOTES

- On the off chance that you feel torment under your knees, take your arms marginally forward. Stay for a couple of breaths, and then gradually leave the posture. Rehash a couple times.

(If you are uncomfortable, then don't interlock your fingers behind your back, just do this Asana with forwarding bend with shoulders under your thighs. Once you are comfortable in this then try this asana with interlock fingers behind your back)

Variations in Kurmasana

- Upside-Down Tortoise Pose (Uttana Kurmasana)
- Sleeping Tortoise Pose (Supta Kurmasana)
- Half Tortoise Pose (Ardha Kurmasana)

Benefits of Kurmasana (Tortoise Pose)

- It stretches your legs, back, shoulders and chest.
- It improves the functions of the respiratory and digestive systems.
- It lengthens the back muscles.
- The organs in the midriff (abdomen) are stimulated during this asana.
- The stance helps you to spread out both your shoulders and your hips.
- The spine is stretched longer during the act of this yoga asana.
- It is considered as an anxiety buster.
- It is beneficial in asthma, constipation and flatulence.
- It is useful in sleeping disorder like insomnia.
- It is beneficial in the problems related to the back or spine.

Note:

Don't try to overstrain your muscles while performing this posture. Breathe in and inhale out the way you would under ordinary circumstances while you are in a definite position of this stance. Avoid this Asana in case of any shoulders, hips or arm injury. Consult a doctor and yoga expert before starting any Asana or Pranayama; don't go beyond your capabilities during Asana.

14. Kakasana

English name: Crow Pose

Kakasana, Kaka = Crow, Asana = Pose, often used interchangeably with Bakasana where Baka = Crane. Both these poses are arm balancing poses. While Crow Pose (Kakasana) has the arms bent like that of a crow bird, in Crane Pose (Bakasana) the arms are straight like that of the crane bird.

In Hatha Yoga, Crow Pose is considered in arm balancing category of poses and can be considered as an advance level yoga pose. For someone who

is very flexible, it can be considered as an intermediate level of yoga pose too. This yoga poses tests the practitioner's level of physical strength, mental strength and emotional strength, hence this is considered as an important yoga pose and in fact an essential pose to master under the Hatha yoga poses.

Kakasana is considered a base pose as kakasana variations can be derived from this pose. Kakasana helps boost energy in the body and hence can be included in flow yoga sequences.

Chakras

Kakasana helps open, activate, and balance the following chakra(s):

- Solar Plexus (Manipura Chakra)

Anatomy

Kakasana benefits the following muscles and hence can be included in yoga sequences with the corresponding muscle(s) focus:

- Middle Back
- Upper Back
- Biceps and Triceps

Kakasana yoga sequences

Kakasana is commonly found in the following types of yoga sequences:

- Arm balancing yoga sequences
- Yoga sequences for improving focus and concentration
- Middle back focused sequences
- Upper back focused sequences
- Yoga sequences for building biceps and triceps

How to do Kakasana

The below cues and yoga sequences added by yoga teachers show multiple ways to do Kakasana depending on the focus of your yoga sequence and the ability of your students.

1. The feet and the hip must be at a width distance. Now bend your knees and bring hands to the mat, keeping fingers open wide and elbows pointing behind. Now place your knees on your triceps , elbows or outer triceps and lift onto your toes. Look forward and lift one foot or both to 'fly'.
2. Release to Child's pose. Lift one leg up at a time to balance. Play around and enjoy experimenting.
3. Take your hands just a little in front of your shoulders. Now lift your hip joint but not too far (upper back and not the hips are the apex of

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the pose). Hug your elbows in. Make sure that the upper back is in line with or higher than your hips. Bend your elbows in and shift forwards. Drop your bum and lift your heels. This will engage the pelvic floor/ upper belly. Sr release to child's pose

4. left one leg up at a time to balance play around and enjoy experimenting
5. -Take hands just a little in front of shldrs -Lift hip joint, but not too far (upper back, not hips, are apex of pose) -Hug elbows in -Upper back is in line with or higher than hips -Elbows bent, shift fwd -Drop bum, lift heels (will engage pelvic floor/upper belly) -Straighten arms, open uppe...
6. bend your knees and plant your hands on the earth shoulder distance apart

   fingers spread wide

   setting up for crow pose

   begin to shift your weight to your hands

   moving your knees toward your armpits

   BREATHING can you approach this challenging pose with curiosity finding balance as you approa...
7. Press palms down and then pull finger tips back a little. Begin to tip weight forwards coming onto toes. Squeeze arms and knees together

   Move gaze forwards of hand to gently lift the head. Play with gentle lifting one foot then the other, maybe both.
8. Place your hands about shoulder width apart on the mat in front of you. Start to shift the weight into your hands. Come up onto your tippy toes and put your knees up as far into your armpit or onto your triceps as you can. Start to lean forward.

   You can stay here, just taking some of the weig...
9. Separate knees / place hands down / lean forward into the arm balance if not arm balancing, find malasana squat if arm balancing, try to get feet up toward bottom
10. Press palms down and then pull finger tips back a little. Begin to tip weight forwards coming onto toes. Squeeze arms and knees together Move gaze forwards of hand to gently lift the head. Play with gentle lifting one foot then the other, maybe both.
11. Use your knees to keep the elbows hugged in Lean far enough forward that your weight shifts fully into your hands Keep a pillow in front of you as a safety net for now :) Stop looking at the pillow Kim. Look forward instead.

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12. From malasana Tuck elbows into new crease Bring weight forward onto hands Push off toes one foot at a time Engage core and tuck tailbone Place bolster in front of needed Slowly start to lower forehead to mat Open chest
13. Assist: ready to catch forward falling at shoulders modifications: pillow under face, hands on blocks
14. Crow Pose is an amazing full body workout. The pose stretches the upper back, helps decrease heart burn and acidity, and increases the flexibility and elasticity of the spine.
15. Keep elbows bent round shoulders / lift hips
16. Invitation to move toward crow pose if in your practice or stay

Kakasana Benefits

There are two types of benefits of doing kakasana:

Mental Benefits

The Crow Pose is considered an arm balance yoga pose and it requires a lot of focus apart from the physical strength. The weight of the body is balanced on the arms and the body weight is at the wrists and elbows. Just like the crow or the crane have a light body for the legs to take the weight, we need to bring that lightness to balance our body on the arms along with proper alignment. The fear of falling on our nose or losing balance and hurting our wrists is most likely to happen if the mind is not ready for these yoga poses (Crow Pose or Crane Pose). Hence Crow Pose builds into the awareness of the body and hones the mind-body connection while 'flying in the air'. Crow Pose also works on emotional state by helping us conquer fear and allowing us to accept and embrace life with courage.

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Physical Benefits

As much as the pose balances the body on the arms and the wrists, it is infact the core strength which is put to test here. Abdominal muscle strength helps us stay in the Crow Pose position, helps the spine stay strong and fit, ensures that the body weight is evenly distributed, helps the legs stay strong and motionless, and finally adds that beauty to the pose. Crow Pose thus builds:

- Arm strength making the more advance balancing yoga poses easier.
- Core strength thus helping tone the abs.
- Builds spine strength and helps gain flexibility.
- Strengthens abdominal muscles and therefore improves digestion.
- Builds physical strength and improves

Kakasana Contraindications

- It is not to be done by someone suffering from **hip injury.**
- Not to be done by someone having **carpal tunnel syndrome.**
- Not to be done by someone who is suffering from **anxiety problems** as Crow Pose (Kakasana) requires a lot of focus and inner strength.
- Not to be done by someone having problems with **migraine,** as in Crow Pose the head is balanced in the air and it could lead to heaviness in the head.
- To be avoided by **pregnant women** because of possibility of falling and increased pressure in the abdominal area.
- Not to be done during the **menstrual cycle** if the bleeding is heavy as there is some stress on the pelvic muscles while holding the pose.
- Not to be done by someone who has **weak wrists** or inflammation in the wrist

Kakasana and Bakasana (Crow Posture and Crane Posture) Difference

Kakasana ('kak' means crow) and Bakasana ('bak' means crane) is one of my favourite poses. This pose is a foundation of all the arm balance postures. When you get this one, many other arm balances and even handstand start to fall in to place.

Kakasana – Crow posture

As we have learnt before, in this asana, on needs to squat on the floor with feet about shoulder width apart. Place the hand flat on the floor in front of the feet with the fingers facing forward. Keep the fingers wide apart. Slightly bend the elbows so that the elbows are facing outwards. Rise on your toes lean forward and place the knee in such a way that the inside of the knee touches the outside of the upper arm as near as possible to the armpits. Lean

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forward further transferring the body weight to the arms and lifting the feet off the floor. Try to bring both the feet together. Hold the final position for as long as is comfortable. Slowly lower the feet to the floor and relax.

For a precautionary measure keep a pillow or some soft cushion in front of you, because there can be a tendency to fall on your face.

Bakasana – Crane posture

Baka means crane. For this posture you have to perform the same as kakasana but you have to keep your knee on the upper arm as near to the armpits as possible, once in the posture try to keep your arms straight (elbow is not bent, crane walks with straight legs and a crow has legs bent). This posture is a little tough than the crow posture so it is recommend to master Crow posture first before trying this.

Bakasana and kakasana are almost similar, except that elbow is straight in bakasana and bent in kakasana so sometimes the names of the postures are interchangeably used.

Variations

Once you perfect the Crane/ Crow postures you can try the variations.

Some of the variations of bakasana/kakasana are

- **Parsva bakasana (twisted crane): -** Squat on the floor with feet and thigh together and balance on the toes. Place the hand flat on the floor shoulder width apart with the fingers facing forward. Keep the fingers wide apart. Slightly bend the elbows so that the elbows are facing outwards. Place the left thigh on the right upper arm by twisting your body. Lean forward and slowly lift both feet above the ground. You can also try the same posture with straight arm, but it will be a little difficult from the bent elbow variation. Hold the final position for as long as is comfortable. Slowly lower the feet to the floor and relax. Repeat on the other side.
- **Ek Pada bakasana (one legged crane): -** Come to the crane posture with bent elbows. Slowly transfer more weight to the left arm and slowly stretch the right leg back until it is straight. Hold this position for as long as is possible. Come back to the initial position and repeat on the other side.

15. Garbha Pindasana

English name: Embryo in the Womb pose

- Garbha: Womb
- Pinda: Embryo
- Asana: Pose

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Garbha Pindasana is the twenty-second pose of the primary series, and the seventeenth seated pose. This is the fourth pose of what is often called the "apex" of the Primary series—five challenging asana in the middle of the sequence.

Garbha Pindasana is a dynamic asana, still for five breaths and nine breaths while moving. The practitioner rolls the length of the spine nine times, said to symbolize the nine months of gestation.

It requires a very specific strength of the deep low belly, and helps to massage and align the spine. Like all of the apex postures of the primary series, it is a deep spinal flexion.

This asana can be performed either in lotus or unbound, with crossed legs. In either case, it's important to keep the spine deeply rounded, in full flexion. Endeavor to bring the hands and the head together, and to keep the hands touching the head while you roll. This will not only make the movement smoother, preventing flailing and throwing oneself about, but also encourage deeper flexion (better roll), and most importantly, force the deep abdominal muscles below the navel to work. If the hands and the head are apart, it's easier to use momentum, or to roll upright by jerking the limbs.

Unbound Form

From seated, cross the legs at the ankle. Flex the feet fully, 'locking' them together, then create stability and strength by trying to actively abduct the legs/pull the feet apart. This helps to make up for the stability that would be gained from binding in lotus.

Next, reach between the legs and either (a) lace the fingers together around the feet or (b) grasp the ears or hair with your fingers.

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Lotus Form

From seated, place the legs into lotus. Squeeze the knees together, tightening the lotus. Reach the arms through the legs until they have passed through the lotus just beyond the elbows. Then, rest the chin in the hands or grasp the ears or hair.

The initial position is to balance on the sacrum for five breaths, as close to the tailbone as possible. After five breaths, rock nine times, turning clockwise each time. Rock all the way to balance on your shoulders. Turn the pelvis slightly, twisting the spine, while on the shoulders in order to turn. If you're grasping the ears or hair while upright, continue to hold while you rock. The hands should not be allowed to come away from the head as you rock. You will likely find this requires an additional, or different, strength.

Each rock should be a controlled alternation between being balanced on the sacrum and on the shoulders, rather than shallow rocks on the torso or overzealous, unbalanced attempts. Use the breath intelligently, exhaling fully and quickly as you rock forward, inhaling as you roll backward. "Control" means that you should be able to stop and balance at any time on either the shoulders or pelvis, and not to rely on momentum to complete the movement.

Vinyasa of the Pose

- From sitting, jump through and land in Dandasana; inhale.
- Exhale, place the limbs in either unbound or lotus form. Lift the legs and balance on the pelvis, as near to the tailbone as possible. Five breaths here.
- Inhale to rock back, exhale to rock forward. Repeat nine times, turning clockwise in a circle.
- Exhale rock forward; release the hands and transition to Kukkutasana.

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Alternatives and Solutions

If you're just beginning, and it's challenging to coordinate turning in a circle while rocking, just rock forward and back without turning. After becoming familiar with the motion, try to incorporate the turn. It's easy to get 'stuck' on your back, or, in lotus, to accidentally roll over onto your side and get stuck. After practicing just forward-and-back for a couple weeks, you'll be able to add the turn in. If you do find yourself getting stuck, try focusing more on moving with the flow of the breath and coordinating a strong exhalation with the rock forward.

It's common when beginning this posture to have difficulty putting the arms through the lotus. You can do one side at a time by, from seated, placing the right arm in the crook of the right knee, then placing the right leg in lotus. Place the left arm in the left knee, then wriggle the left foot into lotus behind the right arm. I don't recommend doing this for a long period of time, but it can help create additional space in the lotus.

Traditionally, the turn is performed clockwise only. However, you may wish to experiment with turning counter-clockwise, as well.

While turning, you will likely roll off of your mat. If the ground hurts your spine, try placing two mats side-by-side for additional padding.

Common Mistakes

- Avoid rocking part-way up and down, rolling only on the mid-back.
- If you're prone to excessive lumbar lordosis, or anterior pelvic tilt, you might find that you're 'smacking' down rather than rolling. Try to emphasize posterior pelvic tilt; you can also try tucking the chin to the chest and grasping the top of the skull rather than the sides, which helps to flex the spine further.

16. Eka Pada Sirsasana

English name: Foot Behind the Head Pose

Eka Pada Sirsasana (Foot Behind the Head Pose) is the best for advanced level practitioners. But it demands the combination of strength and flexibility. So, that's why it comes at the advanced level. Note that, it is not for beginners; Eka Pada Sirsasana is totally hardcore hip –opener as well as directly targets your hamstrings.

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Foot Behind the Head Pose

Eka Pada Sirsasana

Beginners who are looking forward to Eka Pada Sirsasana must first brush up their basics because it's not easy to perform asana. It is better if you practice lots of other hip opener and hamstrings related asanas. Apart from physical demands, it needs your patience. One must not worry if you can't get your leg behind your head in the first attempt. Day by day you feel the improvement but one thing doesn't go beyond over your capabilities.

Asana Name – Foot behind the head Pose

Sanskrit Name – Eka Pada Sirsasana

Asana Level – Intermediate

Focusing Chakra –

- The third eye chakra (Ajna)
- The root chakra (Muladhara)

Meaning

- **Eka** – One
- **Pada –** Foot or leg
- **Sirsasana-** Headstand pose

Steps

- Sit comfortably in the Staff Pose (Dandasana) with legs stretched straight.
- After that, slightly twist (bend) your right knee. Now keep the sole of your right foot to the floor with your left knee.
- Next step, lower your right knee to the right side of the floor. Now open your hip.

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- The movement or rotation of the hip is the important thing for setting up the final position.
- After that, hold/grab your ankle of your right foot. Embrace (hug) your right shin towards your chest.
- But you've to keep your ankle parallel to your other ankle.
- Just grab your right ankle with by your left hand.
- Now it is the important part, slowly – slowly lift as well as draw your right knee towards the shoulder. You have to fit your right ankle behind the neck and left shoulder.
- Your leg touches the neck region, for maintaining the position you may lean forward for few seconds.
- But keep your other leg straight in front of you. Note that your sit bones are strongly placed. Move your right shoulder in a forward direction and your right leg moves backward on the top of shoulder.
- When you feel your right foot is completely tucked behind the neck. Then take your both hands towards the chest and make prayer pose (Namaste gesture). But your hands should touch your chest.
- Now you're in the final position, remain in the pose for five to six breaths.
- Lower down your hands and with the left hand grab the right toe. Unfold your right leg and lower down your right leg.
- Follow the same procedure with your other leg also.

Benefits of Eka Pada Sirsasana (Foot Behind the Head Pose)

- Eka Pada Sirsasana is an awesome hip opener exercise.
- Foot behind the head pose (Eka Pada Sirsasana) lower down your fatigue and stress level.
- Apart from hip opening Eka Pada Sirsasana strengthens and stretches your calves, spinal cord, hamstrings, and hip flexors also.
- The hip opening means you got flexible sitting bones.

Tips for Practitioners

- As you know that, Eka Pada Sirsasana is an intensive Asana. So, perform counter asana just after the practice of Eka Pada Sirsasana.
- You may follow Wheel pose, Ustrasana, Setu Bandha Asana.
- If you feel unbearable pain or strain, then stop the asana.
- Counter poses rejuvenates and release the stress which you get from Eka Pada Sirsasana.
- Remember one thing don't challenge your physical limits.

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Important Notes

- Throughout the process, breathe deeply.
- If you're a new yoga, then avoid Foot Behind the Head Pose.
- Daily practitioners of Yoga, when attempting this first time, please take the help of partner/trainer.
- In case of hip, knee, neck or back injuries strictly avoid Eka Pada Sirsasana.
- It's better if you perform some hip opener asana before performing this asana.
- People with tight hamstrings must also avoid Eka Pada Sirsasana.
- Do not attempt if you have a knee, ankle, back or neck injury.
- It is important to follow the instruction carefully. And perform your posture in a correct way.
- For this, you need a well-certified trainer or teacher. So, don't become a teacher yourself.

17. Krounchasana

English name: Heron Pose

There's a lot going on in Krounchasana (heron pose), which helps open all the major muscle groups in your legs, but don't be daunted because there are also a lot of ways to modify the full position so that it's more accessible. The main stretch here is in the hamstrings, so warming them up first is a good idea. The most common mistake is to let the spine curve forward. It's important to keep the spine nice and straight, so I'll describe some ways to make that happen.

- **Type of Pose**: Seated
- **Benefits**: Stretches the hamstring and calf on the extended leg. Stretches the quadriceps on the bent leg.

Instructions:

- Begin seated in staff pose (dandasana) with both legs extended in front of you and the spine nice and straight. If you usually sit up on a blanket in staff pose to help elongate the spine, you can definitely sue a blanket for the same purpose throughout this pose.
- Fold your left leg back into a half hero pose (virasana) position. Your left foot should be outside your left hip, not under it. Take care to keep the left foot pointing straight back and the left knee hugging toward the midline. If virasana is painful for your knees or doesn't work for you for some other reason, just keep your left leg forward instead, bending the left knee in a one-legged sukasana.

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- Bend your right knee and bring your right foot to the floor close to your right sit bone.
- Hold your right foot with both your hands and lift it off the floor.
- Lean your torso back slightly and anchor your shoulder blades onto your back and your arms into their shoulder sockets.
- Slowly straighten your right leg as much as you can. Remember to keep your spine long and your shoulders down. Don't hunch forward in an attempt straighten your leg more. Your extended leg and your torso should make a narrow V shape.
- Hold for about five breaths and then release and set up for the other side.

Benefits of the Heron Pose (Krounchasana)

- The Heron pose is best forward bend Asana, by which you'll get a good stretch at your legs, back, hamstrings, knees, calves, and hips.
- Krounchasana is amazing hips opener pose.
- The Heron Pose tones your abdominal organs as well as stretches your chest.
- It is very good for people who are facing the problems regarding flat foot
- It is good for your digestive system, and it cures problems related to gas.

Note

Krounchasana is famous for its complexity and it's good if you perform Heron Pose in the guidance of well-certified Yoga expert. If you are very much comfortable with basic level Asana, Then you'll go for it. For better Performance first practice Preparatory Pose. In case of legs, Knees or hip injury strictly away from Krounchasana.

Always prefer well cushioned Yoga Mat and the flat surface of the floor for Practice your yoga session. Never attempt Yogic activities in tight or uncomfortable wearing.

18. Marichyasana

English name: Sage Twist

In the yogic system, there are a number of asanas that evolved over a period of time and achieved a cult status due to specific characteristics. Marichyasana is one such pose that comes in a series of four asanas and is considered a perfect solution for hip related issues. The name Marichyasana is taken from Sanskrit that literally means 'a ray of light'. True to its name, practicing

this yoga asana can assure you miraculous results and relieve your body from chronic pain.

How to do Marichyasana Correctly?

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The four variations of Marichyasana might create a lot of confusion in your mind; if you try to approach the entire series in one go. However, to get holistic health benefits of Marichyasana, you must master one version and then gradually move on to learn others. So, here are the steps of Marichyasana:

- **Step 1:** Initiate this yoga exercise in the Dandasana.
- **Step 2:** Now bend your left knee by putting the heel close to the left sitting bone and keep your knee in such a way that it points upwards.
- **Step 3:** By keeping your right leg straight, try to rotate internally towards the inner thigh.
- **Step 4:** Then push your hands on the bent knee in order to create length in the spine and keeping the sitting bones grounded.
- **Step 5:** Now exhale and fold over the right leg by tucking the left knee into the armpit.
- **Step 6:** Put your left arm forward and try to rotate it internally by pointing the thumb to the ground and the palm to the left side.
- **Step 7:** Further, you must wrap the left arm around the bent leg at the same time keeping the back of your hand near the hip.
- **Step 8:** Now take a deep breath and bring the right arm forward and rotate it internally.
- **Step 9:** You can now wrap your right arm behind the left wrist.
- **Step 10:** Finally, you must exhale in a slow manner and try to fold by keeping the lower abdominal muscles tight and the right leg active and the toes pointing upward.

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Key Health Benefits of Marichyasana

- **Spine Becomes Flexible:** While doing Marichyasana, you actually try to grip the thighs from the behind at the same time interlocking wrists. This puts a lot of pressure on your hip area and eventually creates a balancing state that further helps in the alignment of the lower back. A regular practice of this pose is found to provide additional strength to your sacrum that in the long run works wonders for your spine.
- **Improves Digestion:** This pose requires you to press the lower abdomen and grip it with the thighs tightly. This periodic pressing and releasing of abdomen actually activates the internal abdominal organs and stimulates it further to create a strong digestive system.
- **Increases Concentration Level:** Like so many forward bending asanas, Marichyasana also helps in rejuvenating the mind. When your lower back starts getting flexible after a reasonable period of practice, it also brings calmness to the entire nervous system. Within months of doing this pose, you will be able to focus on work and studies in a better manner.
- **Provides Strength to the Neck:** This wonderful pose requires you to twist and turn the neck and back in a rhythmic manner. Particularly, the forward bend in this asana hugely improves the flexibility of the neck and shoulders.
- **Proper Breathing:** When you pay great attention to your body in a tight hold of this asana, your breath automatically becomes rhythmic. Besides, you are required to inhale and exhale in sync with the body movements while doing this pose which further ensures a perfect way of slow and steady breathing for you.

Seeing the numerous health benefits of Marichyasana, you might get tempted to start this pose right away. However, you must make sure to approach this asana after spending a few months learning the basic poses of yoga. In any case, you should at least do the 'The Dog Pose' as a warm-up exercise before trying the Marichyasana. Apart from this, do remember to perform this pose under the guidance of an expert yoga teacher to avoid any degree of injury to the back.

CULTURAL POSTURES: STANDING TYPE

1.Garudasana
English name: *Eagle pose*
Pronunciation: *(gah-rue-DAHS-anna)*

Garuda = the mythic 'king of the birds,' the vehicle of Vishnu. The word is usually rendered into English as 'eagle,' though according to one dictionary

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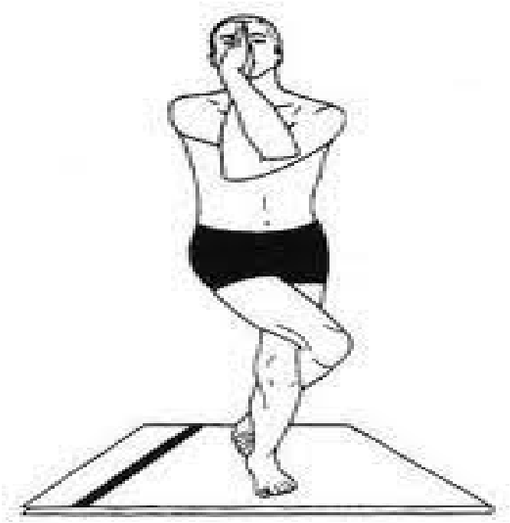
the name literally means 'devourer,' because Garuda was originally identified with the 'all-consuming fire of the sun's rays.'



Eagle Pose: Step-by-Step Instructions

- **Step 1**: Stand in Tadasana. Bend your knees slightly, lift your left foot up and, balancing on your right foot, cross your left thigh over the right. Point your left toes toward the floor, press the foot back, and then hook the top of the foot behind the lower right calf. Balance on the right foot.
- **Step 2**: Stretch your arms straight forward, parallel to the floor, and spread your scapulas wide across the back of your torso. Cross the arms in front of your torso so that the right arm is above the left, then bend your elbows. Snug the right elbow into the crook of the left and raise the forearms perpendicular to the floor. The backs of your hands should be facing each other.
- **Step 3**: Press the right hand to the right and the left hand to the left, so that the palms are now facing each other. The thumb of the right hand should pass in front of the little finger of the left. Now press the palms together (as much as is possible for you), lift your elbows up, and stretch the fingers toward the ceiling.
- **Step 4**: Stay for 15 to 30 seconds, then unwind the legs and arms and stand in Tadasana again. Repeat for the same length of time with the arms and legs reversed.

Contraindications and Cautions

Students with knee injuries should avoid this pose or perform only the leg position.

Deepen the Pose

Look at the tips of your thumbs once you're in the full pose. Typically, the thumb tips point a little bit off to the side of the upper arm. Press the mound of the upper thumb into the bottom hand and turn the thumb tips so they point directly at the tip of your nose.

Theraputic Applications

- Asthma
- Low backache
- Sciatica
- Benefits
- Strengthens and stretches the ankles and calves
- Stretches the thighs, hips, shoulders, and upper back
- Improves concentration
- Improves sense of balance

Variations

Here's a challenging variation of Garudasana. From the pose as described above, exhale and lean your torso into a forward bend, pressing the forearms against the top-leg thigh. Hold for a few breaths, then come up with an inhalation. Repeat on the second side

2. Padahastasana

Sanskrit name: Padahastasana
English name: Hand feet posture

Pada hastasana is a stretching pose. It gives a lot of stretch to your thigh and calf muscle. It also gives a stretch to your lower back. Pada means foot and hast means hand, asana means to be in posture where you can stay firmly and comfortably for longer. Hence Padahastasana is the posture where the feet are touched by the hands.

Padahastasana is also used in the practice of Suryanamaskara. As you have learnt before, suryanamaskara is also known as sun salutation. It comprises of 12 steps. Padahastasana is the second and eleventh step among twelve steps of Suryanamaskara.

There are two techniques of practicing Padahastasana.

Technique 1

- Stand straight.
- Keep your whole body in one line.

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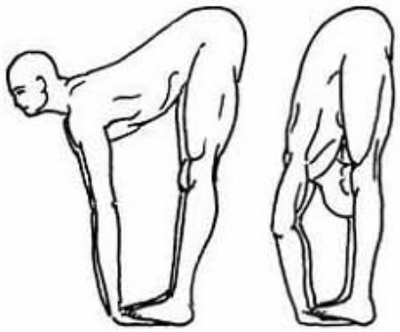
- Legs together, hands by the side of your thighs.
- Chest must be opened.
- Do not tighten your body.
- Just stand firm and straight.
- Now slowly inhale and raise your hand straight upwards over to your head.
- Your biceps must touch your ears keeping the elbows straight.
- Stretch your hands upwards as much as possible.
- While stretching do not bend your neck forward.
- Turn your palms forward.
- Now slowly exhale and start bending forward with lower back.
- Keep your legs straight, do not bend your knees.
- Keep your whole back and hands in one line as your upper body makes an angle of 90◦ with your legs.
- Keep bending forward. First your abdomen touches your thighs and then your chest.
- Now your hold your heels of the feet with respective hands and touch your forehead to the knees.
- Keep your breath out as much as possible or if you can also start normal breathing in the final position.
- Remain in this position at least for 15-30 second.
- Now first lift up your forehead and the hands from the heels.
- Then while inhaling slowly start raising up and stand straight.
- Keep your hands stretched upwards with biceps touching your ears.
- Slowly start exhaling and bring back your hands down keeping the palm on your thighs.
- Apart your legs and relax yourself.
- This is the practice of Pada hastasana.



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Technique 2:

- Repeat the first 6 steps as explained above.
- Now inhale slowly and raise your hands sideways.
- When the hands reach at the shoulder level turn your palm upwards and start raising up your hands over your head.
- Hands must be stretched, biceps touching your ears.
- Now continue the practice as explained earlier.
- After coming back exhale slowly and bring your hands down sideways.
- At shoulder level turn your palms downwards and bring your hands back to the side or you thighs.
- This is another technique to practice hand feet pose.

Benefits of Padahastasana:

- Padahastasana is a very effective practice to remove abdomen fat.
- It is very useful in digestive disorders.
- It gives a nice stretch to the thigh muscles.
- It is a good practice to increase the height.
- It increases the strength of thigh muscles and calf muscles.

3.Chakrasana

English name: Wheel pose

The Chakrasana requires Yoga practitioners to achieve a backward bending posture, which may be difficult to perform initially. But with regular practice and devotion, the Chakrasana can be your best friend, especially if you suffer from spinal issues.

How to Go About It

- Lie down with your stomach facing up and place your hands to the side.
- Bend your knees till your heels are in close proximity to your buttocks. Try to maintain an approximate destination of 1 foot between the heels.
- With hands raised, bring them towards your ears and place them beside the ears, with palms placed firmly on the floor, and facing the respective shoulders.
- Use your feet and hands to elevate the body and stretch thighs and shoulders without straining. The final position resembles an arch or a wheel.

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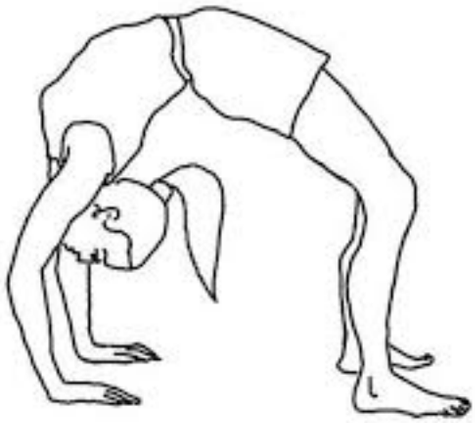
- Once you reach the final position, stay in it for as long as comfortably possible.
- Release it slowly by coming down gradually and then straightening the legs and bringing the hands to the initial position.

The Benefits

- Back muscles and the entire abdomen region is benefited from the practice of the Chakrasana.
- Many internal abdominal organs are given a boost.
- Leg muscles are stretched and strengthened.
- Office goers with sedentary jobs, especially the ones who have to work on computers, benefit from this asana's stress relieving qualities.



Safety Measures

- Achieving the final position through the use of force is absolutely not recommended.
- Novices should begin with the ArdhaChakrasana, a pose which does not require as much stretching as the Chakrasana.

4. Natarajasana

English name: Lord of the Dance yoga

Pronunciation: nut-ah-raj-ahs-anna

Natarajasana or Lord of the dance yoga takes its name from god Shiva-the lord of dancers. Natarajasana is a sanskrit word means Nata-dance, Raja-King, Asana- indicates yoga pose.

Top 10 facts of Natarajasana

1. Its advanced yogasana

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2. Style is vinyasa
3. Initially, it should be maintained for 10 seconds, and gradually time may be increased as per own capacity.
4. It provides stretching from toes to fingers i.e. shoulder, thighs, abdomen, groin, etc.
5. It gives strength to legs, ankles, writs, elbows.
6. It is lord Shiva yoga.
7. It is also called king dancer yoga.
8. It gives a feeling of invigoration
9. It prevents obesity.
10. The pose is of grace nature.

How to do Natarajasana

1. First of all, one should stand erect.
2. Raise either the leg; bend it at the knee; and take it behind the back as high as possible. However, do as per own capacity. Don't take more strain while raising the leg.
3. Now, raise both the hands up, take them backwards and hold toes of the raised foot with both hands above the head as high as possible.
4. Keep your head erect and look at the front.
5. Maintain the pose as long as you can do.
6. Return to the original position.
7. Do the same thing with another leg.

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8. It completes one round.
9. Try to do 2-3 rounds initially.

Natarajasana Benefits

1. **Weight loss**: This is one of few poses, which helps in reducing fat from the entire body. If you are eager to make your body slim and fit, practice the yoga on regular basis. On the other hand, it also boosts your metabolic rate, which helps in fat shedding.
2. **Concentration**: It helps to improve concentration.
3. **Strengthens legs**: The practice of this asana helps to make your legs and arms stronger.
4. **Prevent calcium deposition**: It ensures prevention of calcium deposition in shoulders and brain.
5. **Balance body**: The practice of this asana is good for balancing of the body.
6. **Strengthens ankle**: It makes your ankles, chest and hips stronger.
7. **Abdominal organs**: It gives proper stretch to the abdominal organs. Thus, it is good for digestion.
8. **Flexibility**: If you want to increase your body flexibility, this is one of the best yoga poses.
9. **Stress**: It helps to reduce stress and develop your stamina.
10. **Heart**: The practice of lord of the dance pose is beneficial for heart health.

Yoga Helps in Practicing of Natarajasana

Natarajasana is a balancing and advanced yoga. It needs more concentration and flexibility for one to become a master. But practicing of some yoga

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poses is helpful in the perfection of lord of the dance pose. The preparatory pose are: Adho mukhasana, Dhanurasana, Hanumanasana, Virbhadrasana, Vrksasana, Garudasana, etc.

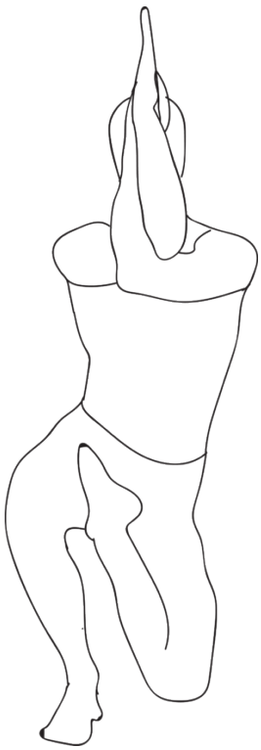
Natarajasana Precautions

Some of the few contraindications of the yoga pose are:

1. Don't do this yoga if you are having low blood pressure.
2. **While** performing this yoga, balancing is utmost important.
3. It is better if one practices this asana before a yoga expert.
4. Avoid excessive stretching.

5. Vatayanasana

English name: Horse pose



Vatayanasana is an Asana. It is translated as Horse Pose from Sanskrit. The name of this pose comes from vatayana meaning horse, and asana meaning posture or seat.

Technique

1. Stand up straight and bend the right leg upwards at the knee so that the heel of your right foot is touching your groin and the toes are placed along the base of your left thigh.

2. Now bend your left knee so as to lower your body till the folded right knee is resting on the ground.
3. You are now standing on your left foot and right knee.
4. Raise both your arms and bend your elbows so that your forearms are pointing upwards.
5. Keep your left elbow in the crook of your right elbow and entwine your right forearm around your lower left arm.
6. The palms of your hands should be together in the namaskar position.
7. Hold this pose for 30 to 60 seconds and then return to your normal position.
8. Repeat the pose for the opposite side, standing on your right foot and left knee.
9. This completes one set. Repeat the set twice.

Effects

- It removes stiffness in the sacroiliac joint.
- It reduces stiffness and pain associated with arthritis.
- It is helpful in cases of inguinal and femoral hernia.
- It reduces cramping in the thigh region.

Special requisites

While performing this pose, you are supposed to take numerous precautions. As this pose is considered as an intermediate level pose, it is difficult for the beginners to perform it.

Initial practice notes

It is advisable for the beginners not to perform this kind of difficult poses alone. You can take the help of the partner in order to complete the pose successfully. Remember that your hips need a certain amount of litheness.

6 Virabhadrasana I

English Name: Warrior Pose

Virabhadra's Pose is also known as the Warrior Pose (there are three variation of Warrior, of which this is customarily numbered I). It may seem strange to name a yoga pose after a warrior; after all, aren't yogis known for their non-violent ways? But remember that one of the most revered of all the yoga texts, the Bhagavad-Gita, is the dialog between two famous and feared warriors, Krishna and Arjuna, set on a battlefield between two great armies spoiling for a fight.

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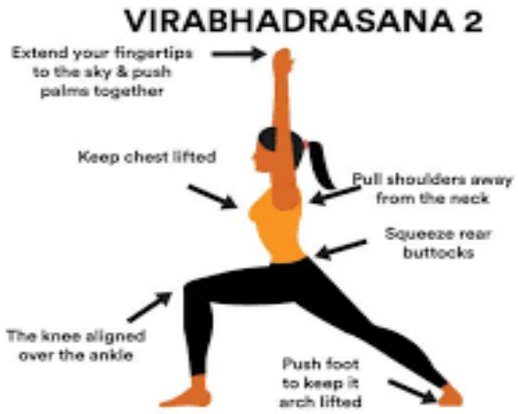
What's really being commemorated in this pose's name, and held up as an ideal for all practitioners, is the 'spiritual warrior,' who bravely battles the universal enemy, self-ignorance (*avidya*), the ultimate source of all our suffering.



Step-by-Step Instructions

- **Step 1**: Stand in Tadasana (Mountain Pose). With an exhale, step or lightly jump your feet 31/2 to 4 feet apart. Raise your arms perpendicular to the floor (and parallel to each other) and reach actively through the little-finger sides of the hands toward the ceiling. Firm your scapulas against your back and draw them down toward the coccyx.
- **Step 2**: Turn your left foot in 45 to 60 degrees to the right and your right foot out 90 degrees to the right. Align the right heel with the left heel. Exhale and rotate your torso to the right, squaring the front of your pelvis as much as possible with the front edge of your mat. As the left hip point turns forward, press the head of the left femur back to ground the heel. Lengthen your coccyx toward the floor and arch your upper torso back slightly.
- **Step 3**: With your left heel firmly anchored to the floor, exhale and bend your right knee over the right ankle so the shin is perpendicular to the floor. More flexible students should align their right thigh parallel to the floor.
- **Step 4**: Reach strongly through your arms, lifting the ribcage away from the pelvis. As you ground down through the back foot, feel a lift that runs up the back leg, across the belly and chest, and up into the arms. If possible, bring the palms together. Spread the palms against each other and reach a little higher through the pinky-sides of the hands. Keep your head in a neutral position, gazing forward, or tilt it back and look up at your thumbs.

- **Step 5**: Stay for 30 seconds to a minute. To come up, inhale, press the back heel firmly into the floor and reach up through the arms, straightening the right knee. Turn the feet forward and release the arms with an exhalation or keep them extended upward for more challenge. Take a few breaths, then turn the feet to the left and repeat for the same length. When you're finished return to Tadasana.

Contraindications and Cautions

- People with high blood pressure should avoid this.
- This is not the right asana for people with heart problems.
- Students with shoulder problems should keep their raised arms parallel (or slightly wider than parallel) to each other.
- Students with neck problems should keep their head in a neutral position and not look up at the hands.

Modifications and Props

Beginners find it very difficult to keep the back heel grounded and the lower back lengthened in this pose. As a short-term solution, raise the back heel on a sand bag or other height.

Theraputic Applications

Sciatica

Benefits

- It stretches the chest and lungs, shoulders and neck, belly, groins (psoas).
- It strengthens the shoulders and arms, and the muscles of the back.
- It strengthens and stretches the thighs, calves, and ankles.

Variations

This pose can be performed with the arms in various positions. For example, go through steps 1 to 3 as described above, except with your hands resting on your hips. Then, once the forward knee is bent, swing your arms around behind your torso and clasp your hands. Stretch your hands away from the back torso and lift your chest. It's acceptable to squeeze your scapulas together at first, but be sure, once the chest is lifted, to push them away from the spine. To leave the pose, reach back with your hands and, with an inhalation, "pull" yourself up, straightening the front knee.

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SUPINE TYPE POSTURES

1.Sarvangasana

English name: Shoulder stand pose

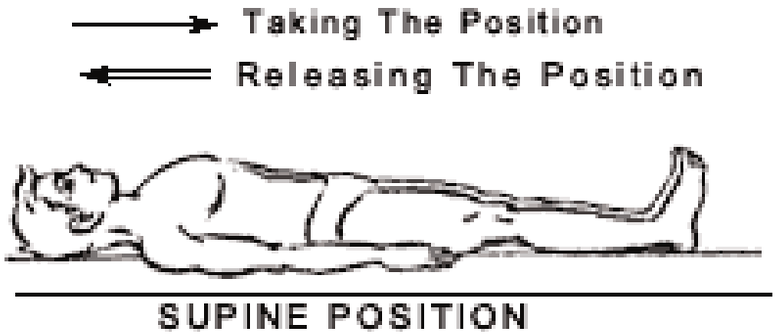
Sarvangasana is one of the best and most important asanas in Hatha Yoga. It has a huge amount of benefits which cover all the body systems.

Sarva - Whole

Anga - Body parts

Asana – Posture

TAKING THE ASANA POSITION:



Exhale and while inhaling, contract the abdomen and slowly raise both the legs to a 90 degree angle from the floor.

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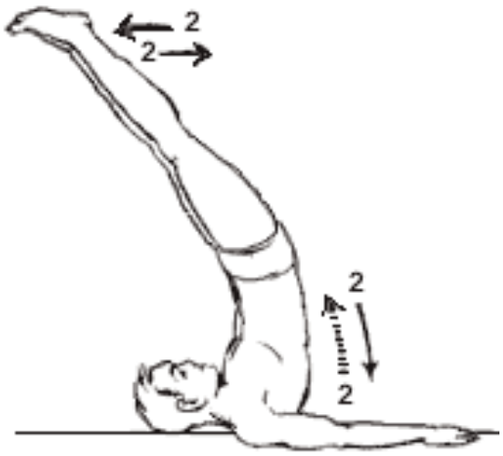
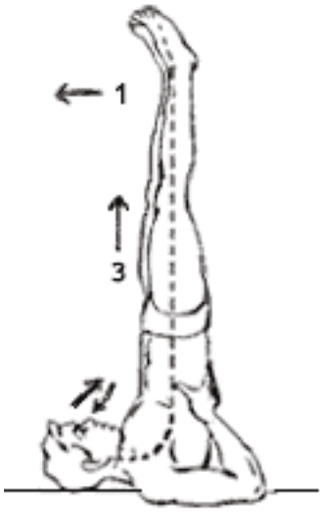


Exhaling raise the waist and the hips from the floor and take the legs backwards over the head.



ASANA POSITION

Inhaling raise the back and the legs up into a vertical position, placing the hands on the upper back for support. The chin should rest against the chest, creating the chin lock. Fix the eyesight on the toes and maintaining the asana, continue normal breathing.

The asana position:

One should concentrate on getting the legs, waist and the back in one straight line and making this line 90 degrees with the ground. In this asana the arms up to the elbows are placed on the floor, shoulder width apart. The body from the feet to the shoulders is in a straight line. The chest is pushed forwards

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and the chin is placed in the throat pit / jugular notch forming a tie which is called 'Jalandhar Bandha'. All the pressure is on the neck, shoulders and the back of the head. The hands are placed on the back ribs, the legs are straight, and the feet are relaxed.

Releasing the asana position:

Inhale and while exhaling bend in the waist and lower the legs over the head, releasing the hands from the upper back.

Inhaling slowly lower the back to the floor, keeping the legs at a 90 degree angle from the floor. Here, lower the back very slowly, vertebrae by vertebrae.

Exhaling slowly lower both legs back to the supine position.

Anatomical focus:

Neck, shoulders, abdomen

Awareness:

- Keeping the body in a straight line.
- Remaining balanced.
- Abdominal breathing.
- The focus can also be on the throat and the thyroid.

Do:

- Keep the legs straight in knees with toes pointing to the sky.
- Try and keep the body in a straight line from the chest to the tips of the toes.
- Head straight and eye sight fixed on the toes.
- Make sure that the trunk is raised enough vertically so that the chin can comfortably rest against the chest.

Don't:

- Bend the knees.
- Move the neck or overstrain it in the chin lock position.
- Bring the legs over the head when in the asana position but don't keep them completely vertical if it causes tension.
- Raise the head from the floor.

Tense the legs or point the feet, as this contracts the legs and prevents drainage of blood.

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Benefits:

- The Jalandhar Bandha improves the function of the thyroid, parathyroid and pituitary glands due to the increase oxygen and blood. All of the other endocrine glands are regulated by the pituitary gland and so the overall function of the endocrine system is improved. This results in the improved functioning of all other systems of the body and the reduction of emotional and mental stress.
- Stagnant blood from the lower regions of the body, i.e. legs and abdomen is drained to the heart thereby improving the supply of fresh blood to these parts and the whole circulatory system. Blood supply to the head area i.e. brain, eyes, ears, nose and throat is improved thereby improving their functioning. Therefore, all of the pelvic and abdominal area circulation, ear, throat and nose ailments are improved.
- The lung capacity is increased as the diaphragm, which is the muscle of respiration, has to work against gravity in this posture, this helps in the abdominal respiration and is therefore helpful in the treatment of asthma. Toxins in the respiratory system are drained thereby improving the respiratory system.
- Prevents and cures varicose veins.
- Detoxification of the body due to improved efficiency of the organs of the body which leads to youthfulness and anti-ageing effects
- Normalizes body weight due to its effect on the thyroid.
- Due to the effect this asana has on the hormonal system, particularly the thyroid, it balances the circulatory, digestive, reproductive and nervous system.
- Due to the increased blood flow to the head, the mind is tranquilized, stress and psychological disturbances are removed.
- The increased blood flow can be beneficial for those who suffer from headaches, though it should not be practiced at the time of headache.
- The thymus gland is stimulated which boosts the immune system.
- It balances the parathyroid glands which ensures regeneration and normal development of the bones.
- It releases the normal gravitational pressure from the anus muscles which helps with haemorrhoids.
- The nerves passing through the neck are toned and the neck flexibility is increased.
- The digestive system is greatly improved due to the increase in blood circulation and drainage of stagnant blood.

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- The pranic flow is harmonized, increasing energy and having a positive effect on all the body systems.
- Sarvangasana has all the benefits of Shirshasana but is safer and easier to perform.

Benefits for Women:

- It is beneficial for the reproductive system as there is fresh blood to the pelvic region as the stagnant blood is flushed from the organs and therefore increased efficiency of the reproductive organs.
- It strengthens the uterine ligaments as the gravity acting on the ligaments in Sarvangasan is in the opposite direction.
- It improves the functioning of the ovaries.
- It helps to balance the moods and calm the mind.

Therapeutic applications:

- Thyroid disorders
- Asthma
- Reproductive problems
- Headache
- Haemorrhoids
- Varicose veins
- Prevention of cough and colds
- Diabetes

Precautions and Contra-indications:

- Should not be performed by people suffering from high blood pressure, heart conditions or brain diseases.
- Should be avoided during menstruation and pregnancy.
- Should be avoided if suffering from a very enlarged thyroid, enlarged spleen or liver as well as cervical spondylitis, slipped disc, headache and weak blood vessels in the eyes.

Duration:

This asana is difficult in the beginning especially for women with heavy hips and men with big bellies. This asana should be maintained for 3 minutes after sufficient practice to get the desired results.

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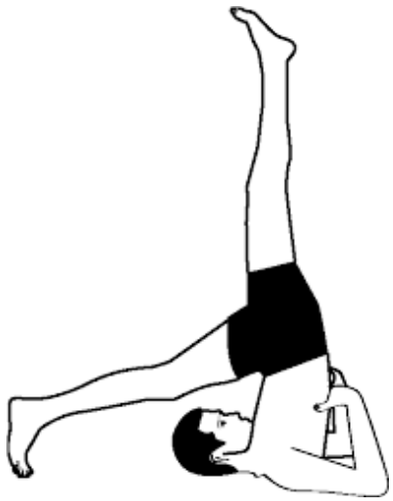
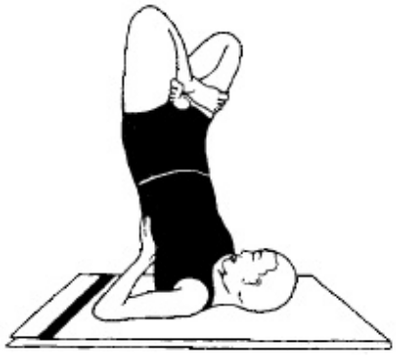
Variations and tips:

- One may need a folded blanket under the neck and shoulders for support.
- For some beginners it may be difficult to raise the legs straight. If so, then one can bend the knees a little while taking the position and then straighten out the legs. Some can take help of the wall to raise the legs.
- If there is tension in the back or neck then the feet can be slightly tilted over the head like inverted pose or viparit karani.

2. Sarvangasana Variations with base pose as Shoulderstand Pose (Salamba Sarvangasana).

As students have varying abilities, a given yoga pose may be easy for a particular student but hard for another. In such cases, as a yoga teacher you can introduce pose variations to further challenge a student who is finding a specific yoga pose easy or introduce an easier variation of a pose for the student who is finding the main pose hard. The following are some variations of the asana.





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Modifications

It is important to understand how a yoga student should enter Sarvangasana (Shoulderstand Pose). In this yoga pose, pressure is more on the shoulders and neck and hence not everyone can practice this yoga pose with ease. Below are some modifications or alternative ways to make it easier to practice Sarvangasana.

Blanket underneath the Shoulders and Neck: A blanket below the shoulders and neck will help give support and make pose a bit easier.

Bend or Incline Legs: Not everyone can raise legs to 90 degrees accurately. So yoga student can start with folded legs or inclined legs in the meanwhile.

Wall support: Using the wall as a support by placing legs high up on the wall while the back is lifted from the floor is also a variation to start with initially.

Half Sarvangasana: You could do the half Sarvangasana by placing one leg on the wall and the other at 90 degrees and alternate the legs to build confidence.

Chair support: One could use a well-cushioned chair to help raise the hips by keeping the chair close to the hips and lower back. This practice is usually done at the B.K.S. Iyengar schools of yoga.

Companion to hold the legs in air: The teacher could help bring the legs up at 90 degrees by holding them for you, thus giving you the confidence to remain there for a longer time.

If your body allows, this beautiful yoga pose should not be missed even if it is hard. It should be worked on gradually step by step as it gives immense benefits to both body and mind and also brings a glow to the face.

While practicing any of these variations, it is important that you do not compromise the comfort level of your arms, neck or the shoulders. Some of these could result in a much deeper level of stretch compared to the traditional sarvangasana. As such, you want to be extremely careful not to overstretch or cause any kind of strain to the body.

You can try to spread the feet wide apart into a V-shape. Hold the position for a few moments. Then, while keeping the legs wide apart, you can attempt a full twisting stretch, twisting the legs in one direction and then the other.

You may attempt lowering one leg overhead (behind you) while keeping the other leg vertical, holding this position for a few seconds, and then switch over to the other leg. You may repeat this sequence one more time.

From the sarvangasana, bend the knees toward the chest and begin to make bicycle-like moves with the legs. You can do a few moves in one

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direction and then a few in the other direction. Finally, get back to the sarvangasana.

You may attempt to get into the Padmasana (Lotus Pose) by placing one foot of top of the opposite thigh and then bringing the other foot also on top of the opposite thigh. You may hold the padmasana for a few moments. Now, you can try the same pose by switching the feet on the thighs. While in the Padmasana, you may like to bend the knees and bring them close to the forehead. This will give a nice, deep stretch to the back as well.

Another variation that you can try is to get into the bridge pose from the sarvangasana. While still supporting the back with your palms, try to bring one foot to the floor and then the other foot as well to get into the bridge pose. Keep the hands supporting the back while you maintain the bridge pose for a few moments. To come out of the pose, you may again want to come up one foot at a time. You can go back to the sarvangasana for a moment.

Finally, you may lower both the legs overhead in the full 'halasana' or 'plough pose'. In this pose, try to keep the legs straight and bring the feet as close to the floor as comfortable. You can keep the palms on the floor in line with the shoulders. If comfortable, you can interlock the fingers behind you, keeping the arms straight on the floor and the shoulders rolled back. This position actually resembles the plough (or plow) after which the pose is named. Maintain the pose for a duration that is comfortable.

While in the supported pose with the palms against the back, try to release the hands down to the floor and continue to hold the legs vertical without the hand support. You may clasp the hands together behind you on the floor. This is called the "Niralamba Sarvangasana" or "Unsupported Shoulder Stand".

3. Halasana

English name: The plough pose

The Plough Pose, Halasana (pronounced *ha-laa-suh-nuh*) is derived from the Sanskrit word '*hala'* which means 'plough'. It is named so because the final pose resembles the plough, an agricultural equipment. Ranging between the difficulty levels of intermediate and advanced, this folded inversion posture is usually best practiced towards the culmination of your Yoga Session. If practiced astutely, this pose elevates your body's state to pratyahara (withdrawal of senses), and you can thus end with a round of pranayama or shavasana.

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Steps to perform Halasana –

- Lying on the floor in a supine position, with the arms alongside the body and palms facing down, bend the knees and kick and rock the legs up and back, bringing the bent knees to the forehead and placing the hands under the hips.
- Slowly, as you exhale, straighten your knees to attain the proper posture. Keep your torso perpendicular to the floor and your legs fully extended.
- Inhale, draw your chin away from your sternum and soften your throat opening up the shoulders and pressing into the ground with the upper arms to create lift.
- To feel the complete benefits of the pose, move the legs as further from the head as possible. At this stage one achieves a chin lock. At this point pressure is put on the thyroid glands.
- Interlace the fingers of your hands behind your back and gently squeeze the shoulder blades together. You may also slide the arms over your head and grab your toes.
- Maintain the position and your breathing for 4-10 counts depending on your level of comfort.
- Finally, exhale as you slowly and easily retrieve your legs from behind your back and place them perpendicular to the mat.
- Return to supine position once again.
- Repeat 3-4 times.

Health Benefits of Halasana

- Improves the tone and strength of back muscles and spinal cord as the back is folded, as well as the leg and abdominal muscles.
- Improves the working of the spinal nerves by creating pressure on the nerves in the neck region which are normally sympathetic, thus enhancing the operation of sympathetic nervous system.
- Improves the function of the thyroid, parathyroid, adrenal, and pituitary glands. All of the other endocrine glands are regulated by these main glands and so the overall function of the endocrine system is improved.

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- Increases blood circulation.
- Good for dyspepsia.
- Activates, warms up, and lightens the psycho – physiological system.
- Useful for asthma, bronchitis.
- Muscles ligaments of thighs and calves gets relaxed and stretched.
- Increases flexibility and provides a feeling of relaxation during leg cramps.
- Makes spinal cord strong and flexible.
- Improves the digestive system, which makes this pose useful who are suffering from constipation and gastric problems.
- Beneficial for diabetic people as it normalizes the blood-glucose level.
- Stimulates the reproductive organs.
- Helps women during menopause.
- Strengthens the immune system
- Therapeutic for backache, headache, infertility, insomnia, sinusitis

4. Karnapidasana

English name: Ear pressure pose

Ear Pressure Pose is a calming advanced pose. *Karnapidasana* is a rare yoga pose that literally does that, illustrating the principle of *pratyahara*. Pratyahara is described as the withdrawal of the senses, meaning shutting out external stimuli so you can turn your attention inward. You can warm up to Ear Pressure Pose with Plow Pose (*Halasana*). It might be used in an advanced hip opening sequence or one focused on the hamstrings.

This pose stretches the neck, shoulders, back, glutes, and hamstrings. The mental benefits of reducing stimuli take practice, but you can get a glimpse into what it might feel like in this pose if you use your knees against your ears to cut yourself off from the sounds around you. To continue your exploration, close your eyes and focus exclusively on your breath for the short

amount of time that you are in this pose. Remember this feeling and try to return to it in your meditation practice during or outside of class.

Step-by-Step Instructions

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1. Begin in Plow Pose with the shoulders tucked under. Your hands can be flat on the floor or interlaced behind your back.
2. Bend your knees and bring them to the floor on either side of your head.
3. Rest the tops of your feet on the floor.
4. Allow the knees to apply light pressure to the ears, momentarily cutting off aural distractions.
5. Take at least five breaths before releasing your arms and slowly rolling out of the pose vertebra by vertebra.

As this pose is an inversion, it should be avoided if you have high blood pressure or a heart condition. You should also not do it if you are pregnant as it compresses the stomach. Avoid it if you have any injury to your neck. If you feel any pain, come out of the pose slowly.

5. Matsyasana

English name: Fish pose

Pronunciation: Mot-see-AHS-anna

matsya = fish

Matsyasana is a reclining back-bending asana. The name is derived from the Sanskrit *matsya,* meaning 'fish,' and *asana,* meaning 'pose.' *Matsya* is also the name of an incarnation of the god, Vishnu, who manifested himself as a large fish in order to save the earth from a flood. As Matsya, Vishnu was able to carry wise Hindu sages to safety, thus preserving the wisdom of all of mankind.

To enter the pose, the practitioner lies flat on the back then lifts the pelvis so the hands can slide under the buttocks. The back arches and the chest lifts until the crown of the head (or the back of the head for beginners) rests on the floor.

Matsyasana may also be referred to as fish pose in English.

This asana is useful for increasing energy levels, relieving anxiety and opening the heart. It is part of the primary series of Ashtanga yoga and is often performed in Hatha yoga as a counterpose for *sarvangasana,* or shoulder stand pose.

In matsyasana, the body is thought to resemble the shape of a fish. It is said that practicing this posture can connect the individual to the balance

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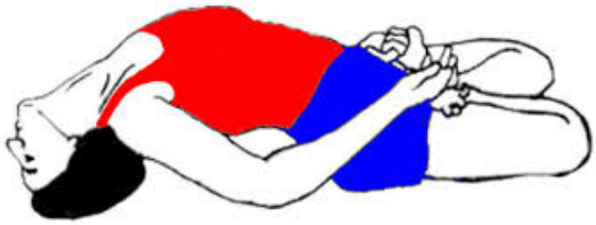
of earth and water, through the grounding of the limbs into the earth, and the lifting of the chest like the crest of a wave.

In a spiritual practice, matsyasana is associated with opening the *visuddha* (throat) chakra. When practicing matsyasana it can be helpful to visualize blue light entering the throat and filling it with energy. Opening this chakra can transform negative energy into wisdom. It also encourages self-expression and aids in any speaking endeavor.

It is said that if you perform the fish pose in water, you will be able to float like a fish.

Traditionally Fish Pose is performed with the legs in Padmasana. Since Padmasana is beyond the capacity of most beginning students, here we'll work either with the knees bent, feet on the floor, or with the legs straight pressed against the floor.



Step-by-Step Instructions

- **Step 1:** Lie on your back on the floor with your knees bent, feet on the floor. Inhale, lift your pelvis slightly off the floor, and slide your hands, palms down, below your buttocks. Then rest your buttocks on the backs of your hands (and don't lift them off your hands as you perform this pose). Be sure to tuck your forearms and elbows up close to the sides of your torso.
- **Step 2:** Inhale and press your forearms and elbows firmly against the floor. Next press your scapulas into your back and, with an inhale, lift your upper torso and head away from the floor. Then release your head back onto the floor. Depending on how high you arch your back and lift your chest, either the back of your head or its crown will rest on the floor. There should be a minimal amount of weight on your head to avoid crunching your neck.
- **Step 3:** You can keep your knees bent or straighten your legs out onto the floor. If you do the latter, keep your thighs active, and press out through the heels.
- **Step 4:** Stay for 15 to 30 seconds, breathing smoothly. With an exhalation lower your torso and head to the floor. Draw your thighs up into your belly and squeeze.

NOTES

Contraindications and Cautions

- High or low blood pressure
- Migraine
- Insomnia
- Serious lower-back or neck injury

Modifications and Props

The backbending position in Matsyasana can be difficult for beginning students. Perform the pose with your back supported on a thickly rolled blanket. Be sure your head rests comfortably on the floor and your throat is soft.

Deepen the Pose

To increase the challenge in this pose, slide your hands out from underneath your buttocks and bring them into Anjali Mudra (Salutation Seal) with arms outstretched and fingertips pointing toward the ceiling.

Theraputic Applications

- Constipation
- Respiratory ailments
- Mild backache
- Fatigue
- Anxiety
- Menstrual pain

Benefits

Matsyasana is considered to be the 'destroyer of all diseases.'

- Stretches the deep hip flexors (psoas) and the muscles (intercostals) between the ribs
- Stretches and stimulates the muscles of the belly and front of the neck
- Stretches and stimulates the organs of the belly and throat
- Strengthens the muscles of the upper back and back of the neck
- Improves posture

6. Setu Bandhasana

English name: Bridge pose

Pronunciation: SAY-tuh-bun-DHAHS-ana.

NOTES

The word Setu Bandha comes from the Sanskrit word 'Setu' which means bridge; and the meaning of Bandha, is Lock or bind, and Asana means Posture, pose or seat.

This Pose called Setu Bandha because in this Asana when we try the pose of this Asana, our body looks like a bridge.

Setu – Bridge; Bandha – Bind, Lock; Asana – Pose, Posture or seat. This yoga pose is pronounced as SAY-tuh-bun-DHAHS-ana.

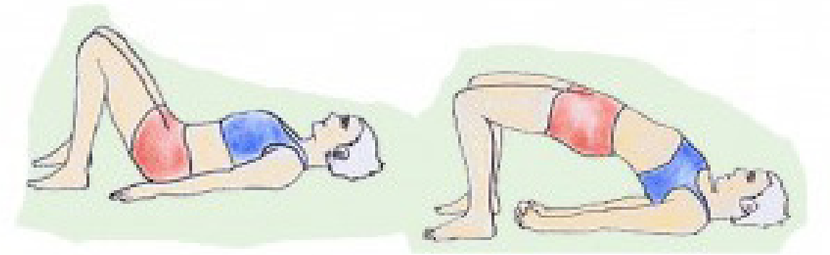
English Name: – Bridge Pose.

Sanskrit Name: – Setu Bandha. (Spinal lift pose).

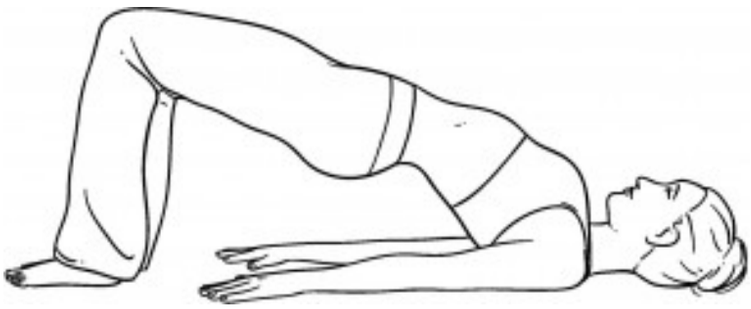
Preparatory Pose: – Savasana.

Steps of Setu Bandhasana

- At first, lie down on your back.
- After that bend or fold your knees and keep your feet and hip distance apart on the floor.
- Distance should be10-12 inches from your pelvis. Along with knees and ankles in a straight line.
- Take your arms beside your body, and your palms should facing down.



- Now inhaling, slowly lift your lower back, middle back and upper back off the floor.
- Now gently roll in the shoulders; touch the chest to the chin without bringing the chin down, supporting your weight with your shoulders, arms, and feet.

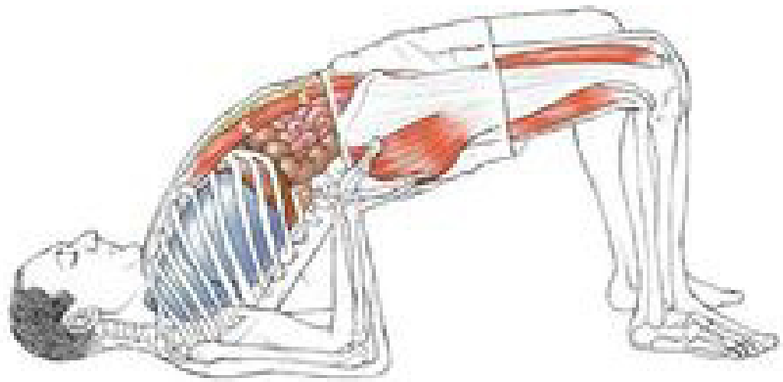


NOTES

- Now feel your bottom firm up in this pose. Keep your Both thighs are parallel to each other and to the floor.
- You may interlace the fingers and push the hands on the floor to lift the torso a little more up, or you could support your back with your palms.
- Keep breathing normally and slowly.
- Remember to hold the posture for 30 seconds or one minute, and exhale as you gently release the pose.

Benefits of the Bridge Pose (Setu Bandhasana)

- Bridge Pose gives strength to your back muscles.
- It relieves the tired back instantly.
- Stretches chest, neck, and spine.
- Gives calmness to brain, reduce the level of anxiety, stress, and depression
- Setu Bandhasana opens up your lungs and reduces thyroid problems.



- Improves digestion.
- Itgood for women in menopause and menstrual pain.
- Helpful in asthma, osteoporosis, and sinusitis high blood pressure.
- This Yoga Pose calms the brain and rejuvenates your tired legs.

Cautions of the Bridge Pose

- Do not try or avoid doing this pose if you are suffering from neck and back injuries.
- At first be perfect in basic Asanas, once you perfect then try this Asana. If you are beginner than the master in basic Asanas after that try this Yoga Pose.

NOTES

- Do all the Asanas in under the supervision of yoga instructor.

7. Urdhva Dhanurasana

English name: Advanced bank bend pose

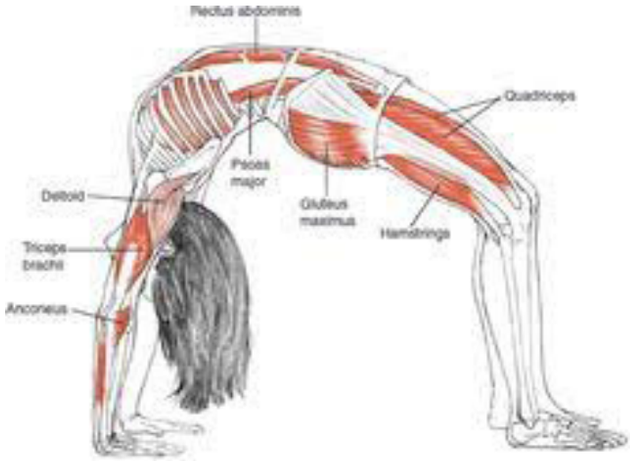
Urdhva Dhanurasana is an advanced backbend pose, an act of displaying orchestrated movements in synchronization with the breath for the upliftment of body, mind, and soul.

Practice Urdhva Dhanurasana with dedication and effort to witness its rewards for the body, mind, and soul. Follow the instructions below for performing the pose:

- Lie in supine on a yoga mat. Bend at the knees and place the feet close to the sitting bones.
- Fold the elbows, keep the forearms perpendicular to the floor, and rest the palms beside the ears with fingers pointing towards the shoulders.
- Press the hands and feet into the ground to push the body up and above from the floor on an exhalation.
- Gently, come into an Urdhva Dhanurasana stance with arms parallel to the yoga mat and shoulder blades against the back.
- Drop down the head and look at the floor.
- Hold this pose for 20 seconds in the beginning and gradually increase the length of the time.

Modify the Pose using Props:

- Practitioners with tight armpits and groins can support the hands and feet on a yoga block.
- Secure a strap around the thighs to keep them hip-width apart and parallel to the ground.



NOTES

Health Benefits of Urdhva Dhanurasana:

- **Opens the accessory muscles:** The human body is composed of numerous muscles performing diverse functions and are often deprived of the care and attention they deserve. One such type is the intercostal muscles in the ribs responsible for opening and shrinking of the rib cage during breathing exercises. Wheel pose duly notices the importance of intercostal muscles and gives them a good stretch for an optimal functioning.
- **Strengthens the arms and shoulder girdles:** If you struggle with weak arms, wrists, and tight shoulders, then Urdhva dhanurasana is worth all the effort and pain. During the practice of this pose, the arms, wrists, and shoulders are actively engaged that helps in creating strength in these body parts along with strengthening the legs, spine, hips, and increasing flexibility.
- **Lengthens the Spine:** Our spine has to suffer a lot owing to the constant sitting and poor postural ways. Also, as we age, the spine compresses. Urdhva Dhanurasana is an effective yogic tool that lengthens the spine and creates the necessary space between the spine keeping it healthy and strong.
- **Fuels the Body and Mind:** A few seconds in the upward wheel pose is enough to make the practitioners feel energized. And, a regular performance of Urdhva Dhanurasana enhances hormonal secretion keeping the body-mind in a vitalized and relaxed state.
- **Stimulates the Thyroid Glands:** Biologically, the Thyroid glands secrete hormones into the body responsible for the efficient working of the body cells. The Urdhva Dhanurasana is an exercise that stimulates the thyroid and pituitary glands helping them to function properly which, in return, takes care of the human body system.
- **Natural Slimming Effect:** The stretching of the body in Urdhva Dhanurasana potently reduces fat buildup from the oblique areas. A devoted practice of this pose is directed towards natural slimming and toning of the body.
- **Therapeutic for Osteoporosis:** The Urdhva Dhanurasana extends therapeutic benefits for back pain and osteoporosis. Practice this pose with the right alignment to savour the health rewards of Urdhva Dhanurasana along with protecting the practitioners from osteoporosis.
- **It's a Heart Opener:** Open your heart to the feelings of love, kindness, and compassion with the Urdhva dhanurasana. It is an excellent heart-opener that expands the chest benefitting the practitioner physically and emotionally.

NOTES

Fold your body into the Urdhva Dhanurasana and leave the mat feeling more energized and alive than ever.

8.Paripurna Navasana

English name: The full boat pose

Sanskrit: परिपूर्णनासन; Paripurna – Full, Nav – Boat, Asana – Pose;

Pronounced as – par- ee-POOR-nah nah-VAHS-anna.

Navasana is an asana. Variations include Paripurna Navasana, Ardha Navāsana, and ekapadanavasana. This asana, if done with great dedication and practice, can be extremely empowering. The Full Boat Pose instills strength and balance in our lives, just as a steady ship moves calmly through the rough seas. The Paripurna Navasana is the full expression of the pose that requires full extension of both the arms and the legs, and the body to be in an acute, boat-like 'V.' This asana is often called the Naukasana.

What You Must Know Before You Do the Asana

You must make sure to keep your stomach and bowels empty before you practice this asana. Have your meals at least four to six hours before you do the asana so that your food gets digested, and there is enough energy for you to expend during the practice.

It is best to practice yoga in the morning. But in the event, you cannot work out in the morning, it is alright to practice it in the evening.

How to Do the Paripurna Navasana (Full Boat Pose)

- To begin this asana, sit erect on your mat, with your legs stretched out in front of you.

NOTES

- Place your hands on the floor, making sure they are slightly behind your hips. Pull your body up, ensuring your sternum is lifted. Lean back. The objective is to straighten your back, making sure it is not rounded.
- Breathe out and lift your legs such that they are at 45-degree angles with the floor.
- Extend your tailbone, and move your hips close to your navel.
- Straighten your knees. Straighten and lift your toes to the eye level. Ensure you are sitting on your buttocks and tailbone.
- Now, raise your arms and stretch them out such that they are parallel to the floor as well as to each other.
- Make sure your lower abdomen is firm, but not thick and hard.
- Breathe normally. Hold the pose for 10 to 20 seconds initially, and as you gain practice, increase the time. Breathe out as you release the pose.

Precautions and Contraindications

This asana must be avoided if you are suffering from the following problems:

- Asthma
- Diarrhoea
- Headaches
- Heart problems
- Insomnia
- Low blood pressure
- Menstruation
- Pregnancy
- Diabetes
- Abdominal injuries/Recent surgeries
- Injuries in the knees, hips, arms, or shoulders

In case you have neck injuries, use the support of a wall to do this asana. Rest the back of your head on the wall as you lean backward in this asana.

Consult a doctor before doing this pose. Make sure you do this asana under the guidance of a certified Yoga instructor, especially if you are a beginner.

NOTES

The Benefits Of The Full Boat Pose (Paripurna Navasana)

These are some amazing benefits of the Paripurna Navasana.

- Practicing this asana makes the spine, hip flexors, and abdomen stronger.
- It helps to activate the prostate glands, kidneys, intestines, and thyroid.
- This asana serves as a great stress reliever.
- The massaging of the abdominal organs helps improve digestion. The digestive system is strengthened as well.
- This asana stabilizes you and also helps you focus better.
- Your hamstrings are stretched.
- The reproductive system is strengthened and toned.

The Science Behind the Paripurna Navasana (Full Boat Pose)

In addition to working your torso and limbs and making your spine stronger, this asana teaches you a lot about yourself – your breath, your emotions, your attention span, and your nature. With practice, this asana moves beyond your body, i.e., the organs, nerves, bones, and muscles, and penetrates into the very core of your being. This asana requires you to draw your spine, abdomen, chest, shoulder blades, the frontal area of the trunk, and your pelvis to the center as your arms and legs stay firm and steady. When you engage your whole body in the Full Boat Pose, you feel strong, both physically and mentally.

When your mind is distracted while you are in this pose, you will tend to lose balance. Make sure to find your stability as you loosen your facial muscles and relax. This is the key to finding stability and balance. Breathe normally.

This asana works on the muscles in the core, but it is very different from the crunches you do at the gym. When you pull your ribs away from your abdomen, you learn how to stretch as well as engage your abdomen at the same time. You lengthen the front of your body in this asana, and it is a requirement when you practice Pranayama. This impacts and improves your breathing as you practice this asana every day.

ADVANCED PRANAYAMA

1. Surya Bhedana Pranayama

Surya means the Sun and according to Yoga, the Surya Nadi is the right nostril. In this pranayama, you use your right nostril or Pingala for inhalation and the left or Ida one for exhalation.

A basic purpose of the right nostril breathing is to increase the pranic energy, physical energy and to revitalize the body. It boosts the nervous system, especially the sympathetic nervous system and also increases the efficiency of digestive system Right nostril is Pingala Nadi, which represents the physical energy of a body. Breathing through right nostril is important for many important metabolic processes.

There are many reasons to do Surya Bhedana (Right Nostril Breathing) pranayama. By practicing a few rounds of Surya Bhedana pranayama each day for a few minutes can help us to control our conscious to some extent.

In the yoga text, *Hath Yoga,* the breath is compared to a wild animal. Just like elephants, lions and tigers are controlled by those who are trained and do practice, in the same way, a yogi also brings the breath under his control with constant practice only. By constant practice of this, we can lose our weight, reduce stress, restore the imbalance in the brain, improve sleep, calm our emotions, boost our thinking and glow like a Yogi.

Benefits of Surya Bhedana Pranayama (Right Nostril Breathing):

- Surya Bhedana Pranayama activates the body and the bodily functions.
- The digestive fire is increased by this pranayama.
- It destroys all diseases that are caused by insufficiency of oxygen in the blood.
- The Hath Yoga says that Surya Bhedana Pranayama cleans the frontal sinuses, destroys disorders of Vata and destroys intestinal worms.
- It activates and stimulates the pranic energy by energizing the Pingala Nadi.
- It helps alleviate dullness, lethargy, and depression.
- It brings fresh energy to the body so one can perform physical activities more efficiently.
- It is useful in treating low blood pressure and infertility in women.
- It increases the body temperature, thus removing the Kafa (mucus) imbalance. This is very effective in obesity. Regular practice of right nostril breath is helpful in weight loss.
- It is very effective for stress management.
- It helps reducing anxiety, depression and other mental illnesses.
- It balances Ida and Pingala and removes all the blockages in the pranic energy channels, which may lead to spiritual awakenings.
- It gives all the benefits of deep breathing as well.

NOTES

Precautions Surya Bhedana Pranayama (Right Nostril Breathing):

- Surya Bhedana pranayama should be practiced on an empty stomach.
- All the inhalations should be done through the right nostril and exhalations through the left.
- It should be done in the morning or evening or both. If you don't have the time in the morning or evening, you can do it at your own convenience.
- Make sure that you practice Surya Bhedana pranayama 4–5 hours after having your food.
- Inhalation and exhalation should be in the ratio of 1:2.
- If you feel even a little bit of discomfort, then you can reduce the ratio of breathing.
- People suffering from heart disease, high blood pressure or epilepsy should avoid this Pranayama.
- People who have undergone brain surgeries, heart surgeries or abdominal surgeries should consult the medical expert or consultant before doing this Pranayama.
- This pranayama increases the heat of your body, so it should be avoided if suffering from fever.

Steps:

- Close the left nostril, using your finger and start breathing in. Try to use full seconds.
- Hold both nostrils, using your thumb and ring finger, and hold your breath.
- Open your left nostril and breath out slowly and steadily.
- Repeat from Step 1.

2. Nadi Shuddhi

Nadi shuddhi is a basic and most widely used form of pranayama and means nadi = energy channel + shuddhi = cleanser. Often, this technique is referred to as Anulom-vilom which means inhalation-exhalation.

Nadi Shuddhi Process

- Sthithi (starting) position: Sit comfortably, preferably in*padmasana* (lotus pose), *siddhasana* or *vajrasana*.
- Place the thumb over the right nostril and the ring-finger + little finger over the left nostril, the other 2 fingers turned into the palm.

NOTES

- Close right nostril with thumb and inhale through left nostril for 4 counts.
- Then, close both nostril for 4 counts & hold breath.
- Release thumb from over right nostril & exhale to 6 counts, increasing to 8 counts as you become confident.
- Close both nostrils and hold breath for 4 counts.
- Repeat using the reverse method.
- Inhale from right, hold, exhale through left, hold.
- This is a round of *nadi shuddhi*.
- Repeat to complete 5 rounds. Rest in between if required.
- Try to increase slowly to 20 rounds.

Over time, you could also increase the ratio of inhalation, holding and exhalation to your comfort. Only, ensure that exhalation is close to twice of inhalation so that lung volumetric efficiency is increased. Also, ensure that the breathing is calm and steady, not erratic and agitated or jerky.

Nadi Shuddhi benefits

- Since the breathing process is steady, over time, the forced volume capacity of the lung increases. Consequently, evacuation of waste gases is increased. As a result, the transfer capacity of the lungs is improved. This increases the oxygen content in the blood stream, with all the resultant benefits to the body.
- Also, left/ right brain activity equalisation is improved by this pranayama.
- The practice of steady breathing reduces stress and purges excess adrenalin and related toxins from the system

Steps for Nadi Shuddhi Technique

- **Step 1:** Sit in Padmasana (lotus position.) Keep your spine erect and your head and neck straight. Close your eyes.
- **Step 2:** Relax the muscles of your body and become aware of your breath. At no point during the exercise, you should control your breath or force it.
- **Step 3:** Place your left hand on your knee while touching your thumb and index finger together. Lift your right hand, let your fingers stretch and bend your index and your middle fingers and place them on the palm of your hand.

NOTES

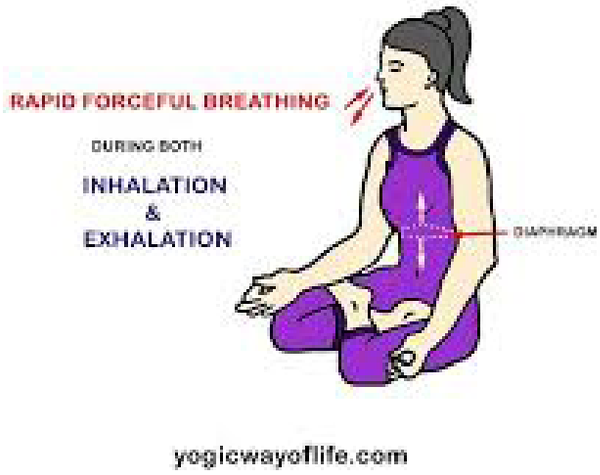
- **Step 4:** Close your right nostril with your right thumb and slowly inhale through your left nostril.
- **Step 5:** Close your left nostril with your right ring finger, release your right nostril and exhale from it.
- **Step 6:** Now inhale through your right nostril, close it with your right thumb and exhale from your left nostril. This completes one round of the exercise.
- **Step 7:** Repeat the whole process at least 5 or 6 times.

Additional Benefits of Nadi Shuddhi Pranayama

Apart from helping with acid reflux, this breathing technique offers several other benefits.

- Purifies blood and improves circulation, resulting in improved functioning of other organs of the body
- Strengthens the lungs and increases overall lung capacity
- Treats disorders of the respiratory system
- Increases energy levels
- Increases metabolism rate
- Reduces stress
- Improves mental health
- Improves appetite
- Strengthens the immune system

3. Bhastrika Pranayama



Bhastrika Pranayama, also known as Bellows Breath, is a heating breathing practice that mimics fanning a fire with a steady flow of air. *Bastrika* is a Sanskrit word meaning 'bellows,' and it describes the active filling and emptying of the abdomen and lungs during this practice. *Bhastrika pranayama* stokes the inner fire of the mind and body, supporting proper digestion on all levels. It is generally balancing for kapha and vata but should be practiced in moderation (and more gently) if pitta is aggravated.

Benefits

Bhastrika Pranayama

- Balances excess vata, pitta (when practiced gently), and kapha
- Burns ama (toxins)
- Cleanses and rejuvenates the lungs
- Increases lung capacity
- Tones the muscles of the heart, bronchial tree, diaphragm, and abdomen
- Helps to strengthen the heart and lungs
- Infuses the blood with oxygen
- Facilitates the proper removal of carbon dioxide from the blood and tissues
- Kindles agni (the digestive fire), and tones the digestive system as a whole
- Cleanses and invigorates the liver, pancreas, and spleen
- Alleviates allergies and asthma
- Cleanses the nasal passages, sinuses, and chest of excess mucus
- Improves circulation
- Supports proper elimination
- Balances and strengthens the nervous system
- Induces a sense of peace, tranquillity, and focus
- Promotes vigour and vitality in the mind and body

Before You Begin

Bhastrika is a more advanced pranayama and therefore requires some familiarity with abdominal breathing. Before practicing *bhastrika,* you should be proficient with more foundational pranayamas, such as Full Yogic Breath. These instructions are meant to provide a safe general introduction to this practice. Of course, it is always best to learn a new technique in person, with a qualified teacher.

NOTES

Contraindications

Bhastrika should not be practiced by pregnant or menstruating women. It is also contraindicated for individuals with high blood pressure, heart disease, hernia, gastric ulcer, epilepsy, vertigo, significant nosebleeds, detached retina, glaucoma, recent abdominal surgery, and anyone at risk for stroke. Those suffering from asthma or chronic bronchitis should practice bhastrika only under the guidance of an experienced teacher.

How to Practice

Bhastrika (as with most pranayamas) is best practiced on an empty stomach. Choose a comfortable sitting position. If you are able, it is best to sit cross-legged on the floor with a cushion or blanket to comfortably elevate the hips. Alternatively, you may choose to sit toward the front of a chair, with your feet flat on the floor. Rest the hands on the knees, consciously opening the chest. Allow the spine to lengthen so that the back, neck, and head are erect. Gently close the eyes and breathe through the nose (you will be breathing through the nostrils throughout this practice).

Begin by taking a couple of Full Yogic Breaths, grounding the mind and gently awakening the prana maya kosha (the energetic body). When you are ready to start practicing *bhastrika,* inhale as in full yogic breath and then exhale forcefully, without strain or tension. As you exhale, allow the abdomen to dynamically contract, drawing the navel toward the spine as the diaphragm ascends toward the lungs. Follow this exhalation immediately with a forceful inhalation—again, without strain or tension. As you inhale, allow the abdomen to actively expand, moving the navel away from the spine as the diaphragm descends toward the pelvic floor. Once again, exhale forcefully, contracting the abdomen and emptying the entire body of breath. Focus on both the inhale and the exhale; their length and force should remain equal as you practice. Observe the breath, the flow of prana, and your dynamic movements as you count ten of these dynamic breaths. At the top of the tenth inhalation, retain the breath for a moment before gently releasing the breath with a long, complete exhalation. Then, take one more deep inhalation and exhale slowly. This completes one round of *bhastrika pranayama.*

During *bhastrika*, breath movements—the expansion and contraction of the abdomen and chest—are slightly exaggerated. If it feels natural, you can allow the hips and spine to gently rock forward with each inhalation, opening the front body, and then allow the hips to rock backwards as the spine contracts slightly on each exhalation. Be careful to keep the body relaxed in the activity—through every inhale, every exhale, and through each exaggerated movement of the abdomen, chest, and spine.

In the beginning, it is important that the breath remain relatively slow—about one breath every two seconds—and that you rest between rounds of bhastrika. With practice, the abdominal muscles will grow stronger and you can slowly build up to five rounds—each consisting of ten forceful breaths, a brief pause at the top of the tenth inhalation, a long, slow exhale followed by one more deep inhalation and a slow exhalation.

When you are ready to close your practice, complete a round with a long, relaxed breath in and out. Then allow your breath to return to normal. Take a moment to observe how you are feeling. Notice your thoughts and your state of mind. Take note of how you feel physically. Are you warmer than when you started? Where do you feel the effects of this practice? When you feel ready, gently open your eyes, continuing to direct some of your awareness within as you slowly stand and offer your full attention to the rest of your day.

There are many variations of *bhastrika pranayama.* Some more advanced techniques incorporate breath retention (kumbhaka), muscular locks (bandhas), breathing through one nostril at a time, and increasing the pace of the breath. These practices are best learned from a qualified teacher.

Bhastrika Pranayama is like Kapalbhati. But in Bhastrika Pranayam, we breathe strongly and then leave it, but in the Kapalbhati, the breath is thrown outside from the nostrils.

In Kapalbhati, our stomach is used, whereas our lungs are used in the Bhastrika. This pranayama does not cause any kind of harm and enhances health, respectively.

3 Types of Bhastrika Pranayama (Bellows Breath)

3 types of Bhastrika breathing techniques – Regular Speed, Medium Speed, High-Speed. According to body health/stamina, one can practice according to these types.

- **Normal speed**

In order to breathe regularly, we breathe at a normal pace and will take out breathing. In it, we do not use power. Take 5-10 seconds to inhale and exhale. This speed is suitable for everyone.

- **Medium speed**

The speed of breathing and exhaling is faster than the normal.

- **High Speed**

At high speeds, one has to breathe rapidly and exhale rapidly. High-speed Bhastrika pranayama is suitable only for healthy and fit individuals.

NOTES

How to Do Bhastrika Pranayama (Bellows Breath)

Follow the steps below carefully and then practice this practice.

- Find a quiet place where the air is fresh, and the atmosphere is clean.
- Holding the Vayu Mudra (Air Posture), sit in the Padmasana (Lotus Pose) and keep a smile on your face. Do not put any stress on the face.
- Exercising by sitting on the east side will give more benefits.
- Leave your body loose, do not put pressure on any part of the body and keep your back straight.
- Take a deep breath (inhale) and then leave the breath completely. Repeat this process 20 times. After practicing 20 times, practice the Maha Bandha and then relax.
- While practicing this, you can pronounce Omkar Japa or Mantras in mind. Think about all the divine powers and energy present in this universe, and I feel that I am receiving all the Divine Powers.
- Practice this 2-5 minutes per day.

Duration for Bhastrika Pranayama (Bellows Breath)

Bellows Breath increases the oxygen level of the body. But the excessive amount of oxygen is harmful to the human body, so in the beginning, practice this pranayama only for 2 minutes, do not exceed it.

After exercising daily, you can practice for 5-10 minutes. Cancer, AIDS, hepatitis etc., patients should practice this pranayama for 10-20 minutes.

For a normal or healthy person, there is a sufficient duration of Bhastrika pranayama for 2-5 minutes.

Best Time To Practice

The best time to practice Bhastrika Pranayama is before sunrise. You can practice Bellows Breath Pranayam before sleeping at night.

Bhastrika Pranayam Benefits

- It helps eliminate excess and toxic elements from the body, resulting in increased blood purity and physical fitness.
- It gives relief from spiritual and physical pain.
- It helps in erasing all kinds of impurities inside the body.
- It strengthens the lung and prevents asthma and tuberculosis.
- It is beneficial in cough problem.
- It gives benefits to good blood circulation.

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- It is beneficial in relieving all brain-related illnesses.
- It is very beneficial for TB, asthma, and cancer patients.
- It enhances the oxygen level of the body.
- It benefits those people who are suffering from diseases like stress, anxiety, paralysis, Parkinson etc.
- It is also helpful in reducing stomach and body fat.
- There are 72 thousand Nadis (veins) in the human body. Bhastrika Pranayam purifies all these veins.
- It is also beneficial in Kundalini awakening.

Precautions While Doing Bhastrika Pranayam (Bellows Breath)

- Practice it at a slow, medium, and fast pace according to health/stamina.
- The seekers of Kundalini Jagran sit in Vajrasana to practice Bhastrika Pranayam.
- If you are still not sure how to do this pranayama, consult Yoga teacher.
- Those whose lungs are weak do not do this Pranayam or practice it slowly.
- If you have high asthma or fever, then do not do this Pranayam.
- People suffering from blood pressure and heart disease should not do it fast. If you are suffering from back pain, asthma, heart disease, then do it very slowly.
- Do not exercise forcefully, while you feel tired, relax while in the middle.
- If you are getting started, then practice bellows breath for only 2 minutes. Do not practice it for more than 5 minutes.
- If a recent operation has taken place, take the doctor's advice before practicing this pranayama.
- Do not shake your body during breathing and removal
- Bhastrika Pranayama Side Effects
- Practicing it for a long period can cause dizziness, anxiety, difficulty breathing. If you feel these kinds of symptoms, stop practicing immediately.

4. Ujjayi Pranayama

Ujjayi Pranayama is a part of the Ashtanga and Vinyasa yoga practices used by the ancient yogis of India. This pranayama derives its name from the Sanskrit word "Ujjayi," which means to be victorious or to conquer. The pranayama is also sometimes referred to as ocean breath or hissing breath. This particular pranayama aims to keep the mind cool and the body warm.

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The practice of Ujjayi pranayama involves deep inhalation from both nostrils with a half closed glottis.

Benefits of Ujjayi Pranayama

- Ujjayi pranayama helps the practitioner to practice superior level of concentration and focus in our daily life. It diminishes distraction and helps the practitioner to become more self-aware of his surroundings so that he does not commit any grave mistakes.
- Practicing this pranayama on a daily basis helps to increase the blood circulation throughout the body and stimulates the overall body metabolism.
- By practicing this pranayama regularly, you can bring about bring positive changes to your physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual wellbeing.
- Ujjayi Pranayama helps the body to get rid of toxins that have accumulated over a period of time.
- Practicing Ujjayi Pranayama helps to release tension. Additionally it also helps to diminish headaches and provide relief from sinus.

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How to Perform Ujjayi Pranayama?

- Be seated in a comfortable position. Relax and be comfortable.
- Gently close your eyes and relax your mouth and jawline
- Practice deep sessions on inhalations and exhalations. Feel the air passing through your wind pipe as you practise the process.
- During exhalation dry to softly utter the sound "ahh" from your mouth.
- Once you become comfortable with the exhalations, maintain a contraction at the back of your throat on inhalation
- Once you get comfortable with this practice, use only the nose for breathing, keeping your mouth shut and maintaining a contract.
- Concentrate on the sound of your breath, which should be audible by now. The inhalations should be able to fill your lungs to the fullest.
- You can start this pranayama for 5 minutes in the beginning and increase the time period up to 15 minutes once you become familiar with the set up.

Precautions

- If you are a patient of hypertension refrain from practicing this pranayama
- If you feel a little warmth in the back of your throat, do not worry. It is normal.
- If you feel dizzy, discontinue the process and start breathing normally.
- Make sure under any circumstances the proportion of the breathing is not forced.

5. Bhramari Pranayama

Bhramari Pranayama, also known as Humming Bee Breath, is a calming breathing practice that soothes the nervous system and helps to connect us with our truest inner nature. Bhramari is the Sanskrit word for 'bee,' and this pranayama is so named because of the humming sound produced at the back of the throat during the practice—like the gentle humming of a bee.

Benefits

- It calms and quiets the mind
- It releases cerebral tension
- It stimulates the pineal and pituitary glands, supporting their proper functioning
- It soothes the nerves

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- It relieves stress and anxiety
- It dissipates anger
- It lowers blood pressure
- It bolsters the health of the throat
- It strengthens and improves the voice
- It supports the healing of bodily tissues
- It induces sound sleep

Contraindications

Bhramari should not be practiced by pregnant or menstruating women. It is also contraindicated for individuals with extremely high blood pressure, epilepsy, chest pain, or an active ear infection. Bhramari should not be practiced in a supine position (lying down).

When to Practice

Bhramari (as with most pranayamas) is best practiced on an empty stomach. While it can be practiced at any time of day, bhramari is particularly potent in the early morning and late at night—when there are fewer distracting noises and our inner perception is most acute.

How to Practice

Choose a comfortable sitting position. If you are able, it is best to sit cross-legged on the floor with a cushion or blanket to comfortably elevate the hips. Alternatively, you may choose to sit toward the front of a chair, with your feet flat on the floor. Allow the spine to lengthen so that the back, neck, and head are erect. Gently close the lips, keeping the teeth slightly apart, and bring the tip of your tongue to the space behind the upper front teeth. Maintain this position of the mouth throughout the practice, frequently checking to ensure that the jaw remains relaxed. Then, close each ear with the thumbs, place the index fingers at the midpoint of the forehead—just above the eyebrows—and reach the middle, ring, and pinky fingers across the eyes so that the tips of these fingers press very gently against the bridge of the nose.

To begin, take a long, deep breath in through the nostrils, bringing the breath all the way into the belly. Drop the chin to the chest and begin to exhale slowly, making a steady, low-pitched 'hmmm' sound at the back of the throat—like the humming of a bee. Focus on making the sound soft, smooth, and steady. The positioning of the tongue allows the vibration to better resonate throughout the head, affecting the tissues of the brain. Keep the body completely still and bring your awareness to the center of the head—to ajna chakra—letting the sound fill the head and spread to the body. Merge with the sound and allow the vibration to permeate your entire being. At the end of the exhalation, slowly straighten your neck as you inhale again

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through the nostrils to repeat the process. Begin with seven repetitions. You may either continue with seven repetitions, or you may add one repetition per week, slowly building up to a total of seventeen repetitions.

After the final exhalation, allow your breath to return to normal and observe any changes that have occurred. How do you feel physically, mentally, emotionally, and spiritually? What energetic shifts do you notice as a result of this practice? Where do you notice sensation in your body and how is it different from when you started? When you are ready, gently open your eyes, continuing to direct some of your awareness within. If it is morning, slowly stand and offer your full attention to the rest of your day; if it is evening, notice the vibrational calm that this practice has initiated in your body and try to maintain it as you prepare to retire for the night.

The above instructions are meant to provide a safe and general introduction to the practice of bhramari. Advanced practitioners sometimes add variations such as breath retention (khumbaka), muscular locks (bandhas), and may also hum on the inhalation—as in ujjayi pranayama. These additional techniques are best learned in person from a qualified teacher.

6. Sitali Pranayama

Sitali pranayama is a yogic breathing exercise that is designed to both calm the mind and cool the body. The term comes from the Sanskrit, 'sitali', meaning 'cooling' or 'soothing'; prana, meaning 'life force'; 'andayama', meaning 'extension.' To practice sitali pranayama, the tongue is rolled and then the breath is drawn in through the tongue as if through a straw.

Sitali pranayama differs from many other types of pranayama that are intended to warm the body.

In yoga, sitali pranayama can be used to regulate the body temperature and still the mind after asana practice. It is particularly useful in hot weather. Sitali pranayama is also recommended by practitioners of the traditional Indian medicine of Ayurveda as a treatment for a *pitta dosha* imbalance. The pitta dosha is the body bio-element that controls metabolism, energy production and digestion.

Because of its cooling effect, sitali pranayama is believed to benefit the nervous system and endocrine glands. It is also thought to offer the following benefits:

- Reduces excess bile
- Reduces fever
- Controls hunger and thirst
- Relieves stress

Yogis who find it difficult to roll the tongue may practice a related cooling pranayama called sitkari, in which the breath is drawn in through the mouth with closed teeth

Practice

Sitali Pranayam is a great breathing exercise for relieving anxiety and addictions, detoxification, clearing anger, and quitting smoking. Practicing will produce a powerful cooling, relaxing effect on the body, while maintaining alertness. It is known to lower fevers, and aid digestion. This is a great technique to do if you find yourself freaking out emotionally or caught up in anger – it will cool you down and bring you back to calm.

If you are new to doing Kundalini Meditations on your own, make sure to read how to do a home practice before you begin.

Get Started

Sit in a comfortable posture with the spine straight.

Breath

Take the tongue and curl it into a 'U', with the tip just outside of the lips. Inhale deeply through the curled tongue; exhale through the nose.

If you can't curl your tongue, just stick your tongue out over your bottom lip and feel the air rushing over the togue on each inhale.

Time

Continue for a minimum of 2-3 minutes.

For detoxification, practice this pranayam 26 times in the morning and 26 times in the evening.

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How It Works

Sitali Pranayam gives you power, strength, and vitality. It is helpful to practice whenever you get a fever, sickness or discomfort. It is a cure within you. At first the tongue will be bitter (a sign of toxicity), then it will become sweet. Once it becomes sweet, it is a sign that toxins have been eliminated and you are less likely to become ill. Sitali Pranayam helps to eliminate anger, brings sweetness to the personality, and strengthens the nervous system. Sitali Pranayam also soothes and cools the spine in the area of the fourth, fifth and sixth vertebrae, which helps to regulate sexual and digestive energy.

Great powers of rejuvenation and detoxification are attributed to this breath when practiced regularly. 'People who practice this breath have all things come to them that they need by the planetary ether. In mystical terms, you are served by the heavens.'

This is also an excellent technique to decrease cravings for cigarettes. Simply practice for 3 minutes before every cigarette you intend to smoke and see what happens.

7. Sitkari Pranayama

Sheetali pranayama and Sitkari pranayama steps both are similar and effective to cool down your body temperature and high blood pressure. But in Sheetali pranayama, you roll your tongue to make a tube, in Sitkari breathing exercise, you will have to touch the tongue upwards. Let's check what are the steps and benefits of Sitkari breathing exercise.

Sanskrit Language – Sitkari

Sitkari – Hissing

Pranayama – Breathing Exercise

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Sitkari Pranayama Steps

- Sit on the ground comfortably (Sukhasana or Padmasana).
- Keep breathing normally for a few minutes and relax.
- Now touch upper and lower teeth together and touch your tongue upwards.
- Open your lips and start inhaling deeply which produces a hissing sound.
- Hold your breath for few seconds then exhale through the nose.
- Remember that the duration of exhalation should be twice of the inhalation.
- Again, inhale and exhale as per above steps. Repeat this for 10-15 times.

Sitkari Pranayama Benefits

- Cools down your body
- Lowers down your high blood pressure.
- Reduces the excessive stomach heat
- Reduces pitta dosha
- Calms your mind and reduces stress
- Reduces your anger and fatigue
- Improves health of teeth

Sitkari Precautions

- Should be avoided in an AC room or winter season.
- Should be done on an empty stomach and in a fresh air.
- Low blood pressure patient should not practice Sitkari breathing exercise.
- If you are suffering from cold, cough, constipation or asthma then avoid it.
- If you are not able to practice Sitkari breathing exercise then you should practice Sheetali Pranayama.

Inhalation (Puraka), Retention Holding (Kumbhaka) and Exhalation (Rechaka)

Patanjali describes Pranayama as the pause or the rest period after an inhalation seizes and before an exhalation begins. Then there is another pause after an exhalation seizes and beforean inhalation commences again. Yogic

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Pranayamas are mainly centered around these two pauses cycling between the inhalation and the exhalation.

Thus, a Yogic Pranayama has four sections: inhalation known as Puraka; pause after inhalation or holding of the inhaled air known as Kumbhaka; exhalation is known as Rechaka; pause after exhalation or suspension after the air is exhaled and before next inhalation begins, also known as Sunyaka.

The below given four techniques are based on these four stages of the breathing process. When individually mastered they bestow the benefits of a healthy breathing on the practitioner of these Pranayamas. For all the four techniques explained below the digits depicted against the arrows are the number of counts that process needs to be done too.

One count is equal to 1 second and the practitioner can increase counts at one count per week keeping the overall proportion the same. The counts shown in the illustrations for each Pranayama are basic counts for the beginners. A maximum of 10 rounds is recommended for a single sitting on each Pranayama explained.

Use all the three muscles: diaphragm, clavicular, and intercostal for doing these Pranayama exercises.

1. Puraka (Prolonged Inhalation)

For doing this pranayama sit in any meditative posture with your shoulders, facial muscles and elbows relaxed. Place your hands on the thighs above the knees. Close your eyes, keep the spine erect and the chin remains parallel to the ground. Start inhaling after a short exhalation (just to provide a lift).

The inhalation has to be smooth and bereft of jerky movements throughout this Pranayama practice. Continue inhaling till you can in this manner or until no part of the body experiences any strain. The moment strain sets in, release the effort (that's your inhalation capacity's limit) and breathe normally for a round or two. Beginners can start with 2 rounds as exhalation and then 5 rounds as inhalation.

Persons suffering from Cardiac issues, Hypertension, and pregnant women should avoid this Pranayama exercise.

This Pranayama exercise would force open every unused alveolus (Air Cell) in the lungs along with stimulating the sluggish ones. Since the inhalation process is prolonged here, more oxygen is ingested and made available for the body cells to be used, boosting the overall health in general. it also helps increase the breathing lung capacity.

2. Kumbhaka (Prolonged Inhalation and Retention)

The preliminaries and the sitting posture remains the same as explained above in context to Puraka Pranayama above.

Begin by exhaling for a short duration (just to provide the kick lift to the consequent inhalation) of 2 counts and immediately after start inhalation. Inhale to the count of 4 and then retain or hold to the count and 5, after which release or exhale the held up air in a smooth manner without any jerk in the process.

Persons with Cardiac issues, Hypertension, Asthma, Bronchitis & Abdominal Inflammation, Pregnant women who have reached the sixth month of pregnancy, Children under the age 12 years should avoid doing Kumbhaka Pranayama

Regular practice of Kumbhaka Pranayama will establish the regulation of breath improving the regular respiration of the practitioner. This Pranayama aids with concentration and intrapulmonary and intrathoracic pressure and overall health. increase the lifespan. Along with increasing the lung capacity it also helps reduce the strain on the circulatory system. The practitioner also experiences improved

More energy is released into the system as Glucose metabolism gets a kick due to the practice of Kumbhaka Pranayama. It also helps with increased positivity and sattvic state of mind.

3. Rechaka or Prolonged Exhalation

The preliminaries and the sitting posture remains the same as explained above in context of Puraka and Kumbhaka Pranayamas. For Rechaka, beginners can start by inhaling for 2 counts, holding for 4 counts and then exhaling for 8 counts. Draw your abdomen inwards while exhaling and when the exhalation is complete suspend for 2 counts, then release the abdomen. Take some normal breaths between two rounds of Rechaka Pranayama.

Persons with severe cardiac problems (the Controlled Cardiac problem will benefit from this Pranayama), Hypertension, Pregnant women and children under the age of 12 years must avoid doing this Pranayama.

A large volume of Carbon Dioxide gets eliminated by doing Rechaka Pranayama regularly, this eases the nerve Asthmatics gain from this practice as exhalation issues are a corollary to Asthma. It also helps reduce blood pressure and facilitates the feeling of let go in general. Rechaka stimulates and inspires the brain. It also exercises the Diaphragm and restores its effectiveness related to ventilation of the lungs.

4. Sunyaka or Prolonged Exhalation and Suspension

All the preliminaries and the body position remains the same as mentioned for the other three Pranayamas. Sunyaka Pranayama is also known as Vaccum Breathing.

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Start by inhaling to 2 counts. Suspend the breath for 5 counts after exhaling for 4 counts. Once the suspension is complete release it by inhaling in a smooth manner.

Persons with severe cardiac issues, Abdominal ulcers, abdominal surgeries, low blood pressure conditions and children under the age of 12 years must avoid doing Sunyaka Pranayama.

This Pranayama preserves the tone and elasticity of the Diaphragm. It is extremely useful for week Stomach and weak Colon. Regular practice of Sunyaka Pranayam helps correct conditions like inflated lungs and Tachycardia. It induces thoughtlessness. Blood pressure is reduced by doing Sunyaka, along with abdominal organs. Elimination of toxic Carbon Dioxide. It helps to improve blood purification and circulation by applying internal pressure on the abdominal organs.